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Govt to decentralise animal welfare with district SPCAs



BUSINESS: Pg 11

Govt directive to offer 60% flight seats free of charge put on hold



FILM: Pg 16

'Don't glorify your mother's pain'



— IRAN FIRES ON ISRAEL, GULF NEIGHBOURS | MILITARY OPTION TO REOPEN HORMUZ IS UNREALISTIC: MACRON —

In address, Trump says ‘finish the job’

Iran President Pezeshkian goes Trump-style: Addresses Americans directly

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON/ DUBAI: President Donald Trump said US forces will “finish the job” in Iran soon as “core strategic objectives are nearing completion”, offering a full-throated defence of the war on Wednesday night in his first national address since the conflict began more than a month ago.

He used his platform to tout the success of the US operations and argue that all of Washington’s objectives have so far been met or exceeded, but said Iran would continue to face a barrage of attacks in the short term.

“We are going to hit them extremely hard over the next two to three weeks,” Trump said. “We’re going to bring them back to the Stone Ages, where they belong.”

But Trump also spent much of an address that lasted just under 20 minutes repeating many things he had already said in recent weeks and providing few new details.

The effect on global financial markets was more immediate, with oil rising more than 4 per cent and Asian stocks falling after Trump’s comments about the US continuing to hit Iran hard.

The president didn’t mention the possibility of sending US ground troops into Iran. Nor did he reference NATO, the trans-Atlantic alliance he has railed against for not helping the US secure the critical Strait of Hormuz, where a chokehold by Iran has sent energy prices soaring.

Trump ticked through a timeline of past American involvement in conflicts and noted that the ongoing war in Iran had lasted just 32 days, seeming to appeal to the public for more time to achieve the mission.

“World War I lasted one year, seven months and five days,” he said. “World War II lasted for three years, eight months and 25 days.” Trump also added references to Korea,



President Donald Trump arrives from the Blue Room to speak about the Iran war from the Cross Hall of the White House on Wednesday

AP/PTI

WAR WARNINGS MOUNT

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» MORE THAN 1,200 PEOPLE HAVE BEEN KILLED AND MORE THAN 1 MILLION DISPLACED IN LEBANON. TEN ISRAELI SOLDIERS HAVE ALSO DIED THERE

» Hours before Trump’s address, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian posted a lengthy letter in English on his X account appealing to US citizens and stressing that his country had pursued negotiations before the US withdrew from that path

» More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran during the war, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel. More than two dozen people have died in Gulf states and the occupied West Bank, while 13 US service members have been killed

INDIA JOINS 60 NATIONS IN UK-LED TALKS TO REOPEN HORMUZ

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India on Thursday raised concern over maritime security and energy stability amid the grappling global situation due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. India’s Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri voiced the country’s concern

while participating in a high-level meeting convened by the United Kingdom virtually. More than 60 countries participated in the meeting.

In his remarks at the meeting, Foreign Secretary Misri noted the importance of the principles of freedom of navigation and unimpeded

transit through international waterways. He emphasised the impact of the crisis on India’s energy security and the fact that India remains the only country to have lost mariners in attacks on merchant shipping in the Gulf. He also underlined that the way out of the crisis consisted of de-escalation and a return to the path

of diplomacy and dialogue among all concerned parties, according to a statement by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

At the invitation of the UK, India joined the meeting to explore ways to reopen the vital Strait of Hormuz, whose closure has sent oil prices spiralling, the MEA said.

See P8

The president encouraged countries reliant on oil through the Strait of Hormuz to “build some delayed courage” and go “take it”.

In a social media post Wednesday morning, meanwhile, Trump also wrote that

“Iran’s New Regime President” wanted a ceasefire. It wasn’t clear to whom the US president was referring since Iran still has the same president.

Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesman, Esmail Baghaei, called Trump’s

Continued on P4

— ASHOK MITTAL STEPS IN AS DEPUTY LEADER AMID RIFT BUZZ —

AAP power play in RS, Raghav Chadha out

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Thursday replaced its deputy leader of the party in Rajya Sabha, Raghav Chadha, with Ashok Mittal, amid buzz over his alleged differences with the top leadership.

Party leaders confirmed that a letter was sent to the Rajya Sabha secretariat seeking the removal of Chadha from the post of deputy leader of the party in the Upper House.

“Rajya Sabha secretariat was made aware of the par-



ty’s decision,” Aam Aadmi Party leader of the House in Rajya Sabha Sanjay Singh told mediapersons.

AAP leaders refuted the

The move comes amid Chadha’s prolonged silence on matters related to the AAP, and his absence from several public events led by Kejriwal

claims that Chadha was prevented from speaking in the Rajya Sabha under the quota of the party MPs.

Talking to reporters, Mit-

tal said the AAP’s national convener Arvind Kejriwal has entrusted him with the role of the party’s deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, and he will discharge his duties sincerely and present both the party’s stance and national interests forcefully in the House.

Mittal, Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab and Chancellor of private Lovely Professional University, said, “Everyone gets time to speak in our party; it is a democratic process. Raghav Chadha will also be given time to

Continued on P4

NETS VS SKY



Fishermen spread out a net with dark clouds hovering in the backdrop, in Mumbai, on Thursday

PTI

Duty waiver boost for petrochem imports

West Asia crisis

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday exempted import of critical petrochemical products from customs duty for three months till June 30, giving relief to sectors like pharmaceuticals, chemicals and textiles, and ensuring supply stability amid the ongoing West Asia crisis.

The “temporary and targeted relief” will cost the exchequer about Rs 1,800 crore, but help ensure price stability, continuity in production and supply chain, CBIC Member (Tax Policy), Sanjay Mangal told reporters at a press briefing.

In a statement, the finance ministry said in light of the ongoing conflict in West Asia and the consequent disruptions in global supply chains, the government has decided to provide full customs duty exemption on critical petrochemical products till June 30.

Sectors dependent on petrochemical feedstock and intermediates such as plastics, packaging, textiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, automotive components and other manufacturing segments will benefit from the duty exemption which will cost the exchequer Rs 1,800 crore. “This measure has been taken as a temporary and

Continued on P4

— LIKELY TO RUN FOR 3 DAYS —

Session returns Apr 16

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Budget Session of Parliament will reconvene on April 16 after a brief recess to pass Bills to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats from 543 to 816 so that the women’s reservation law can be implemented at the earliest, in what is expected to be the latest flashpoint between the government and the opposition amid the poll season.

While the government is keen on passing the Bills, including amending the women’s reservation Bill or Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, the Opposition has accused the Centre of trying to hurriedly move for passing amendments to take political advantage in the state elections.



The two Houses will reconvene on April 16, with sources saying that the sitting will likely be for three days to take up the proposed legislations. The government is learnt to have conveyed to the Opposition parties that the Houses are likely to meet for three days beginning April 16.

Sources said that the Bills for implementation of the women’s quota law would likely to be brought in Lok Sabha first.

Earlier in the day, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, while

Continued on P4

Silent exodus: Over 20 lives lost daily abroad

Five-year data reveals steady toll, majority of deaths reported from Gulf nations



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Disturbing statistics about the conditions of Indian workers abroad reveal that over 20 individuals have died on foreign soil each day over the past five years, with most fatalities occurring in Gulf nations.

According to data provided by Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh in a written reply to the Rajya Sabha on January 29, the total number of Indian worker fatalities abroad reached 37,740 between 2021 and 2025. A breakdown of the cause of these deaths was not provided.

The data showed that the highest number of deaths occurred in 2021, with 8,234 Indian workers losing their lives abroad. Follow-

The total number of Indian worker fatalities abroad reached 37,740 between 2021 and 2025. A breakdown of the cause of these deaths was not provided

ing a dip to 6,614 deaths in 2022, casualties have risen steadily year-on-year, reaching 7,291 in 2023, 7,747 in 2024, and 7,854 in 2025.

Gulf countries accounted for over 86 per cent of these deaths. The United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Saudi Arabia recorded the highest number of casualties, with 12,380 and 11,757 deaths, respec-

tively, in the five-year period. They were followed by Kuwait (3,890), Oman (2,821), Malaysia (1,915), and Qatar (1,760).

During this period, Indian missions overseas received 80,985 complaints of abuse, exploitation, and workplace grievances from Indian nationals. UAE accounted for the highest volume of these grievances, with 16,965 complaints registered between 2021 and 2025. It was followed by Kuwait (15,234), Oman (13,295), and Saudi Arabia (12,988).

A 2018 PTI report, based on analyses of Right to Information (RTI) responses and Parliamentary records highlighted by the Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (CHRI), showed that nearly 10 Indian workers died every day in the Gulf region

Continued on P4

DELHI POLICE MAINTAIN CALM

Hanuman Jayanti processions pass off peacefully under heavy security

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police heaved a sigh of relief after processions of Hanuman Jayanti went off peacefully in the national capital on Thursday, with no major law and order issues reported from any part of the city, officials said.

The police remained on high alert throughout the day as multiple processions were taken out across sensitive areas, particularly in northwest and southwest Delhi.

An officer said that three separate processions were carried out in the Jahangirpuri area, which has previously witnessed communal violence during a Hanuman Jayanti procession in 2022.

"To ensure a peaceful event, a total of 13 companies of paramilitary forces were deployed, along with more than 2,200



A person offers prayers to Lord Hanuman on 'Hanuman Jayanti' PTI

police personnel in the area. Elaborate security arrangements, including surveillance and area domination exercises, were put in place," the officer said.

An intense vigilance in the area was mounted in the run-

up to the festival, including flag marches and motorcycle patrols across key stretches of the northwest district.

Meetings with local stakeholders were held to maintain communal harmony.

According to officials,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Three separate processions were carried out in the Jahangirpuri area, which has previously witnessed communal violence during a Hanuman Jayanti procession
- » 'To ensure a peaceful event, a total of 13 companies of paramilitary forces were deployed, along with more than 2,200 cops'

CCTV cameras and drones were used extensively to monitor the movement of processions, while barricades were installed at strategic points to regulate crowd movement and prevent any untoward incident.

Another officer said that in

southwest Delhi's Uttam Nagar, one Hanuman Jayanti procession was taken out peacefully under strict security cover.

"Security arrangements were tightened in Uttam Nagar as well, especially in view of a recent incident of violence in the area last month. The procession concluded without any disruption," the officer said.

The area was on edge following the March 4 killing of a 26-year-old man in a row on Holi, prompting a heavy deployment of police forces for several days.

"Area domination exercises and flag marches were conducted to instil a sense of security among residents. Local intelligence inputs were also actively monitored," another officer said. "No incidents were reported from anywhere in the city. All processions passed off peacefully," the officer said.

4 injured as CNG cylinder explodes at Dwarka pump

Pump attendants among injured; one critical

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Four people were injured, one of them critically, after the CNG cylinder of a truck exploded during a refill at a CNG pump on the Najafgarh-Mittraon Road in Dwarka on Thursday, police said.

According to police, information about the blast was received from the Rao Tula Ram Memorial (RTRM) Hospital, where the injured are being treated.

A pump attendant was filling compressed natural gas (CNG) in the truck when one of its cylinders exploded, injuring four people present on the spot.

Three of the injured have been identified as Deepak (34), Vikas Kumar (26) and Neeraj (40), all pump attendants.

The condition of the fourth man, whose identity is yet to be ascertained, is stated to be critical, police said.

TAKEAWAYS

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» The condition of the fourth man, whose identity is yet to be ascertained, is stated to be critical, said police

Forensic and Crime Branch teams have inspected the scene to ascertain the exact cause of the explosion.

Technical experts and representatives from the gas agency are also present at the site to assist in the probe, police said.

"Preliminary inquiry sug-

gests that the explosion took place during routine refuelling, though the exact reason is yet to be ascertained," a senior police officer said.

The authorities are examining whether there was any technical fault in the cylinder or a lapse in the safety protocols at the filling station.

Palam: 3 in cop net for illegal LPG storage, refilling racket

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have arrested three individuals for allegedly running an illegal LPG storage and refilling racket from a residential area in Palam Village in southwest Delhi.

Acting on a tip-off, a team from Police Station Palam Village conducted a raid on March 28 at a vacant plot in Adarsh Gali. The accused — Anaar Singh of Jai Vihar, Najafgarh; Satyaveer of Tamil Enclave, Dabri; and Vikas Kumar of Raj Nagar-II, Palam — were apprehended at the spot.

Police recovered 45 Bharat Gas cylinders, a tempo used for transportation, and equipment allegedly used for transferring gas. Officials said the accused were refilling cylinders using nozzles and a weighing machine without any safety measures and could not produce valid licences.

During questioning, the trio allegedly admitted to renting the plot to store cylinders and refilling them for profit. The operation was suspected to be linked to staff of Blue Flame Gas Service in Janakpuri.

The SDM of Dwarka, along

LPG black marketing busted in Alipur raid

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Thursday launched a crackdown on illegal LPG refilling and black marketing, conducting a raid in Alipur and initiating legal action against those involved.

The operation was carried out by a joint team of the Food & Supplies Department and oil marketing companies following inputs from a sting operation aired a day earlier. During the raid, officials detected illegal refilling of LPG cylinders, a hazardous practice that poses serious safety risks and disrupts the regulated supply system. Authorities also seized three consumer passbooks allegedly used to procure subsidised cylinders for illegal resale. An

FIR has been registered and materials recovered from the site have been confiscated.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta reiterated the government's strict stance, stating that "any attempt to exploit consumers or manipulate LPG distribution will invite the strictest possible action." She added that there is "zero tolerance towards black marketing and hoarding," while assuring that there is no shortage of LPG supply in Delhi.

Government approved 13 SDM-led teams for inspections and surprise checks across LPG networks, urging citizens to report suspicious activity, with crackdown to ensure safe, fair, uninterrupted supply. MPOST

with officials from BPCL and the Food Safety Department, inspected the site and confirmed the illegal activity. A case has been registered under relevant provisions of

the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Essential Commodities Act. All seized items, including cylinders and equipment, have been taken into custody, and further probe is underway.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have registered a case following a complaint by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) over the alleged circulation of unauthorised and purported official documents on social media.

According to police, the complaint was received on March 12 at I.P. Estate police station from an authorised FSSAI representative. It alleged that certain social media influencers and unidentified individuals were sharing the documents online, possibly to create distrust and harm the organisation's reputation.

Police sources said the circulated material resembled official FSSAI communication. However, the authority expressed concern that the documents may have been accessed without authorisation and potentially tampered with before being shared. The complaint also flagged the possibility of insider involvement in obtaining and disseminating the material.

An FIR has been registered under Section 316 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and

KEY POINTS

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Section 72 of the Information Technology Act, which pertain to unauthorised access, misuse of information and breach of confidentiality.

Investigators have begun examining the authenticity of the documents and the role of individuals involved in posting and spreading them. Digital evidence is being preserved, and notices have been

issued to social media platforms, including X, seeking details of accounts linked to the posts.

Officials said the probe is at an early stage and is looking into multiple aspects, including possible unauthorised access to official records and the intent behind the circulation. Further action will follow based on the findings.

Man fatally stabbed at girlfriend's house

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: A 25-year-old man was stabbed to death at his girlfriend's house in Roshan Nagar, with five people, including a juvenile, apprehended, police said on Thursday.

The victim, Manas Rai of Jaitpur in Delhi, had gone to meet the woman on Wednesday night with his friend Harsh. According to his father's complaint, the woman's relatives

and others, including the main accused Aman, arrived at the house soon after.

Police said Aman allegedly attacked Rai with a knife, while others assaulted him and Harsh, who was injured while trying to intervene. Rai later died during treatment at Safdarjung Hospital. An FIR has been registered at Palla PS.

Police said a previous dispute may have led to the attack, and efforts are on to arrest Aman.

JNU students' union alleges neglect of library

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union has alleged severe neglect and mismanagement of the Ambedkar Central Library at Jawaharlal Nehru University, claiming that the condition of the facility has deteriorated significantly.

In a statement, the union said a recent inspection of the library revealed extensive damage, including broken windows, exposure of books to dust and moisture, and lack of proper



maintenance. According to the union, a majority of windows in the building are damaged, leading to unhygienic conditions, with pigeons entering

freely and damaging books. It also alleged that several books remain uncatalogued and are lying in piles.

The union criticised the administration over the absence of a permanent Chief Librarian, stating that an acting official has been holding charge for several years without addressing key issues. It termed the situation as "vandalism" of an important academic resource and demanded immediate intervention.

In a separate development, JNUSU also raised concerns

regarding ongoing student issues, including shortages of LPG cylinders affecting mess and canteen services. The union alleged that students are facing reduced menus and increased costs, adding to their difficulties. It further claimed that attempts to meet university officials, including the Dean of Students, were unsuccessful, with authorities either unavailable or unwilling to engage. The union also highlighted delays in hostel allotments, stating that several students are still awaiting accommodation.

BETWEEN CONTROL AND EXPRESSION

Delh Univ's uneasy campus climate

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A series of developments at University of Delhi has triggered widespread protests, reflecting a growing churn over student rights, campus governance and administrative policies.

At the centre of the unrest is a new regulation mandating prior permission for protests at least 72 hours in advance. While the administration maintains that the move is aimed at ensuring security and maintaining order, students and faculty argue that it restricts democratic expression and undermines the culture of dissent historically associated with the university.

Tensions escalated following allegations that a cultural



programme organised under the Shaheed Yaadgari Abhiyan at the Arts Faculty to commemorate Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev Thapar, and Shivaram Rajguru was disrupted. Students claimed they faced intimidation prior to the event and confrontation during it, with reports alleging damage to posters of the martyrs.

Adding to the controversy are protests against events

“The unrest also coincides with a 17% fee hike for the 2026–27 academic session, drawing criticism from students who say it will make edu less accessible”

linked to the RSS-backed "Yuva Kumbh", raising concerns among sections of students and teachers over ideological neutrality on campus. Recent administrative measures to tighten rules on gatherings, following incidents of violence, have further intensified the standoff. The unrest also coincides with a 17 per cent fee hike for the 2026–27 academic session, drawing criti-

cism from students who say it will make education less accessible. Simultaneously, concerns over campus facilities have surfaced, with students of Miranda House staging a protest over poor food quality and inadequate portions in the hostel mess. Carrying empty utensils, the students highlighted what they described as prolonged neglect despite repeated complaints.

With multiple issues converging from restrictions on protests to rising costs and basic amenities Delhi University appears to be navigating a critical moment, as students continue to assert their demands for accountability, inclusivity and the preservation of democratic spaces within campuses.

L-G felicitates traffic 'praharis'

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday felicitated 21 Traffic Praharis for their role in enforcing road discipline, and honoured citizens who reported violations through the Traffic Prahari app under an incentive scheme.

During his visit to the Traffic Headquarters in Todapur, the LG flagged off 38 scooters for women traffic personnel to enhance mobility and response in congested areas. Two disaster response vehicles equipped



for road emergencies were also deployed. Sandhu reviewed traffic operations, including enforcement and public interface systems. MPOST

NEW SPCA FRAMEWORK TO REPLACE DSPCA

Govt to decentralise animal welfare with district SPCAs

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a significant administrative reform aimed at improving animal welfare, the Delhi government under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has decided to constitute Societies for Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (SPCAs) in all 13 revenue districts of the national capital.

The move comes in the wake of the recent reorganisation of districts and is intended to strengthen the implementation of the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960 at the grassroots level. Each SPCA will be headed by the respective District Magistrate (DM), ensuring direct administrative oversight and quicker response to cases of animal cruelty.

Officials said the district-level committees will include experts and individuals associated with animal welfare,



'Protecting animals is a mark of a sensitive and responsible society' PTI

allowing for better coordination between enforcement authorities and civil society stakeholders. The Chief Minister emphasised that decentralising the system would make it more efficient and responsive to complaints.

Highlighting the impor-

ance of the initiative, Gupta said, "Protecting animals is a mark of a sensitive and responsible society," adding that the government is committed to building a more humane and accountable framework for animal protection.

At the state level, the Animal

HIGHLIGHTS

» Officials said the district-level committees will include experts and individuals associated with animal welfare, allowing for better coordination between enforcement authorities and civil society stakeholders

» CM emphasised that decentralising the system would make it more efficient and responsive

Welfare Board will function as the apex body overseeing the entire structure. It will monitor implementation, provide technical and financial support, and ensure that district SPCAs function effectively. This integrated approach is expected to significantly enhance the

capacity of the system.

In a key structural change, the government has also decided to dissolve the existing Delhi Society for Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (DSPCA). Officials noted that the new framework would replace fragmented mechanisms with a more streamlined and coherent system, improving accountability and efficiency.

Gupta expressed confidence that with District Magistrates leading the committees, cases of cruelty would be addressed more swiftly, with improved monitoring and coordination on the ground.

The Chief Minister said the combined framework of the Animal Welfare Board and district SPCAs would deliver tangible improvements in animal welfare outcomes, ensuring stricter enforcement of laws and greater awareness across the capital.

Capital ready for another artificial rain experiment

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi may witness another cloud-seeding trial this summer, according to an official familiar with the matter. Two rounds of cloud-seeding trials were conducted in the national capital late last October.

The trials came following a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Delhi Environment Department and the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kanpur, signed on September 25, 2025.

The experiment, however, failed to cause any rain in the city. IIT Kanpur, in a statement, attributed the failure to low moisture levels in the clouds.

The institute, however, said that the observations from the trials would strengthen planning for future operations and help them identify the ideal conditions.

Cloud seeding is a weather modification technique designed to enhance a cloud's potential to produce rainfall. It involves dispersing substances such as silver iodide and



As part of the trial last year, each time, eight chemical flares containing silver iodide and sodium chloride were released

other compounds into clouds to trigger changes, promoting the formation of ice crystals or raindrops.

As part of the trial last year, each time, eight chemical flares containing silver iodide and sodium chloride were released.

In the wake of the experiment, the Delhi government

released a report, claiming that the trials helped reduce particulate matter at targeted locations.

Now, IIT Kanpur has approached the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) for a renewed permission for another trial.

"IIT Kanpur is going through the findings and studies that they got from the last two trials, following which a further trial might be planned this summer, though the final time will be decided by IIT Kanpur. The final findings will be shared with the government at a later stage by the institution," the official said.

The Economic Survey of Delhi 2025-26, released on March 23, also mentioned that more cloud-seeding trials will be conducted in consultation with the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The trials have been envisioned as part of a short-term emergency measure for artificial rainfall generation to disperse and reduce ambient air pollution levels, the survey said.

CM Gupta visits Karol Bagh Temple & offers prayers on Hanuman Janmotsav

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Marking the occasion of Hanuman Janmotsav, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday visited the 108-ft Shri Sankat Mochan Dham temple in Karol Bagh, where she offered prayers for the well-being, peace and prosperity of the people of the capital.

The Chief Minister participated in rituals at the temple and joined devotees in reciting the Hanuman Chalisa. The visit witnessed the presence of a large number of devotees, temple authorities and dignitaries, creating a spiritually charged atmosphere.

Speaking on the occasion, Gupta highlighted the enduring relevance of Lord Hanuman's ideals. "His ideals continue to inspire us to



serve society and the nation selflessly," she said, describing him as a symbol of service, dedication and courage. She added that such religious occasions play an important role in promoting unity and positive energy in society.

Extending her greetings to citizens, the Chief Minister expressed hope that the blessings of Lord Hanuman would bring "lasting peace, happiness and prosperity" to Delhi. She also urged people to imbibe values of har-

mony, cooperation and service in their daily lives.

During her visit, Gupta interacted with devotees and members of the temple trust, acknowledging their role in organising the event. She reiterated the Delhi government's commitment to preserving the city's cultural and spiritual heritage, stating that such celebrations strengthen social bonds and collective positivity.

Officials said the visit was part of the government's broader efforts to remain connected with cultural and religious traditions across communities in the capital.

Hanuman Janmotsav, celebrated across the country with devotion, marks the birth of Lord Hanuman and is observed with prayers, bhajans and recitations, drawing large gatherings of devotees at temples.

Kidnapping accused escapes police custody

NEW DELHI: A 24-year-old man, accused in a kidnapping case, allegedly escaped police custody through a bathroom ventilation window of a guest house in southwest Delhi's Mahipalpur area, official sources said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Sahidur Rahman alias Aalu, a resident of Manipur, had been booked at Irlbung police station in Imphal district. Acting on a tip-off, a Manipur Police team arrested him on March 27.

He was produced before a court in Saket the next day, which granted a three-day transit remand to the Manipur Police, the source said.

Before leaving for Manipur, the police team checked into a guest house in Mahipalpur and stayed in a room along with the accused.

"On the night of March 28, the accused sought permission to use the bathroom. After he failed to return for a considerable time, the officer grew suspicious and checked inside, only to find the bathroom empty," the source said.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the accused had escaped through the bathroom's ventilation opening. The team rushed outside and managed to catch him briefly, but he managed to free himself and fled into the crowd, evading capture. Following the incident, the Manipur Police informed the Delhi Police. A case was registered at Vasant Kunj North Police Station on March 29 based on the statement of a sub-inspector.

Police teams are scanning CCTV footage from the guest house and nearby areas and conducting raids to trace the accused. Efforts are underway to apprehend the accused at the earliest, and an inquiry has also been initiated into the lapse in custody. PTI

NDMC plans Suvidha Camp on April 4 for public services

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council will organise its monthly Suvidha Camp on April 4 at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road, as part of its ongoing efforts to strengthen citizen engagement and streamline grievance redressal.

The camp, scheduled from 10:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m., will function as a single-window platform enabling residents to access a wide range of civic services and resolve issues through direct interaction with officials. The initiative is aimed at improving service delivery and ensuring quicker resolution of complaints.

Residents, Resident Welfare

Associations (RWAs), Market Traders Associations (MTAs), and both serving and retired NDMC employees have been invited to participate. Officials said the camp is designed to provide on-the-spot assistance and clarity on procedures related to municipal services.

A range of issues can be addressed at the camp, including electricity-related services such as new connections, disconnections, load changes, and name transfers. Citizens can also raise concerns regarding property tax, birth and death certificates, waterlogging, sanitation, waste management, and road maintenance. In addition, assistance will be provided for pension schemes, including those for widows, senior cit-

izens, and persons with disabilities, as well as bookings for community spaces like Barat Ghars and public parks

Dedicated helpdesks staffed by officials from multiple departments will be set up to ensure time-bound responses and efficient handling of grievances. The civic body noted that such camps are held regularly on the first Saturday of every month at the same venue, reinforcing its commitment to accessible governance.

NDMC has launched the Jan Suvidha Portal, enabling residents to lodge complaints online, track their status and share feedback, in a move aimed at enhancing transparency, accountability and efficiency in civic service delivery.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A month-long special sanitation drive undertaken by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi has resulted in the removal of over 1.52 lakh metric tonnes of construction and demolition (C&D) waste from across the Capital, officials said on Wednesday.

The drive, conducted between March 6 and March 31, focused on clearing debris from roads, drains, lanes and public spaces, with the aim of improving urban cleanliness and ensuring smoother civic infrastructure. Authorities said sanitation teams across all MCD zones were mobilised in a coordinated manner, with additional manpower and machinery deployed to intensify operations.

Each zone was supported



with nearly 50 extra sanitation workers, while heavy equipment such as backhoe loaders, highway machines and specialised vehicles were used to handle large accumulations of debris. Smaller and scattered waste was also cleared by ward-level teams using auto tippers and other civic resources.

According to officials, around 79,406 metric tonnes of waste was lifted by the MCD, while the remaining 72,737 metric tonnes was cleared with support from other departments. The waste was transported to designated pro-

DMRC: Filming reels, abusing and fighting top offences, 8,000+ commuters penalised

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Filming reels, abusing and fighting have emerged as the most common offences in the Delhi Metro, with 2,468 commuters penalised between September and February. This was followed by unlawful entry into the women's coach, which saw 2,313 penalties.

A total of 8,251 penalties were imposed -- 1,316 in September, 1,381 in October, 1,275 in November, 1,242 in December, 1,656 in January, and 1,381 in February -- indicating stricter enforcement and varying commuter behaviour, an official said.

Nuisance-related violations, including filming reels inside trains, using offensive language, quarrelling and acts

2,249 commuters were penalised for sitting on the floor inside trains. Cases of spitting accounted for 767 penalties

of indecency, remained consistently high throughout the period. Month-wise data showed 447 such cases in September, 357 in October, 410 in November and 408 in December, before rising to a peak of 501 in January and dropping to 345 in February.

Unlawful entry into women's coaches was the second most reported offence, with 2,312 penalties during the period, with January recording the highest at 559 cases, compared to 261 in September, 426 in October, 317 in November,

284 in December and 465 in February, the DMRC said.

Similarly, 2,249 commuters were penalised for sitting on the floor inside trains, the official said and added that the monthly figures stood at 408 in September, 395 in October, 287 in November, 345 in December, 394 in January and 420 in February.

Cases of spitting accounted for 767 penalties, with a gradual decline towards the end of the period, and there were 134 and 137 cases in September and October, respectively.

The number rose to 187 in November before dropping to 107 in January and 85 in February, he said.

Drunkenness led to 126 penalties overall, with figures fluctuating across months, he shared and said the cases stood at 14 each in September and October, rising to 29 in November, followed by 22 in December, 23 in January and 24 in February.

Unlawful track entry led to 277 penalties, while 43 were fined for quarrelling and nine for carrying offensive items. Proposed amendments may raise fines up to Rs 10,000, aiming to deter violations while decriminalising minor offences under metro laws. PTI

DoE GREENING PLAN

3.5L saplings to be planted in schools

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has drawn up an action plan to intensify tree plantation and greening activities across schools for the academic session 2026-27, setting a target of planting 3.5 lakh saplings.

According to the plan issued by the Directorate of Education (DoE), the target includes one lakh trees and 2.5 lakh shrubs to be planted in government, government-aided and private unaided recognised schools through Eco-Club members.

The move follows what officials described as "commendable" plantation efforts by schools during 2025-26, and aims to further expand green cover and curb pollution levels within school campuses.

Heads of Schools (HoSs) have been directed to under-

take a series of measures, including awareness campaigns on tree plantation and increasing green patch areas using grass and creepers. It stated that schools have also been asked to ensure the planting of trees and shrubs on a monthly basis.

To encourage student participation, institutions will organise activities such as poster-making, painting, role play, nukkad natak, essay writing and slogan competitions centred on greening initiatives, it said.

As per DoE, a special plantation drive has been scheduled for August 11, 2026, with schools expected to achieve 80 per cent of their plantation targets by that time.

Schools must plant 350 saplings each, monitor survival, submit monthly reports; officials to ensure maximum plantation across campuses.

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh on Thursday flagged off a new fleet of mechanised vehicles aimed at strengthening sanitation services and enhancing preparedness for monsoon-related water logging across the Capital.

The fleet, inducted by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, includes 16 backhoe loaders, two CNG-powered flood control emergency vehicles, and six mechanical road sweepers. The initiative marks the second phase of adding advanced machinery to the civic body's operational network.

Addressing the event, Singh said the government is committed to making Delhi "clean, green and healthy," adding that visible changes are now being seen on the ground. He expressed confidence that improved infrastructure and



proactive measures would prevent severe water logging during the upcoming monsoon season.

Highlighting the growing challenge of urban flooding due to heavy rainfall, inadequate drainage and rapid urbanisation, the Mayor said the newly inducted flood control vehicles are equipped with pumps capable of removing up to 10,000 litres of water per minute. The vehicles, each costing ₹87.02 lakh, have been certified by Indian Institute of Technology Delhi and will be

operated under an Operation and Maintenance model.

The six mechanical road sweepers, with a capacity of 4.5 cubic metres, are expected to enhance mechanised cleaning and help control dust pollution, while also reducing the risks faced by sanitation workers. Each unit costs ₹58.69 lakh.

Further strengthening waste management operations, 16 new backhoe loaders have been added, taking the total number to 68. These machines, fitted with multipurpose buckets, are designed to handle mixed waste efficiently and reduce manual labour.

Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma said the induction represents a step towards modernising civic operations, while DEMS Committee Chairman Sandeep Kapoor emphasised that mechanisation would improve efficiency and ensure timely civic response.

New kennels to increase capacity at Najafgarh dog centre

NEW DELHI: To address overcrowding at dog shelters, the MCD has begun construction of additional kennels at a dog sterilisation centre in southwest Delhi's Najafgarh, officials said on Thursday.

The kennel is expected to accommodate an additional 450 to 500 more dogs every month, they said. The project, being executed at the Bijwasan sterilisation centre run by an NGO, involves the construction of 14 new kennel units. "Around Rs 28 lakh has been allocated to the engineering department of the Najafgarh zone," an official said, adding that construction began about 15 days ago and is expected to be completed within 60 days.

Each kennel unit, measuring approximately 7 by 8 feet, is being built under a covered truss structure.

"A tin shed will cover the

entire plot. There are seven units on each side with a central corridor in between. Grills will be installed up to a height of seven feet," the official said. He added that the design ensures proper ventilation and protection from weather conditions.

Officials said the expansion is aimed at strengthening the Animal Birth Control (ABC) programme by increasing the intake and sterilisation capacity of stray dogs. Meanwhile, the civic body had earlier proposed another shelter at Bella Road with 40 kennels to further enhance capacity at ABC centres.

In January, the MCD had also announced plans to set up kennels at five new centres and expand infrastructure at five existing sterilisation facilities to accelerate sterilisation and anti-rabies vaccination drives. PTI

'ENERGY INSTABILITY IN REGION'

Hormuz disruptions have caused huge economic impact: Navy chief

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Strait of Hormuz disruptions have caused severe economic impact and energy instability in the region, Indian Navy chief Admiral D K Tripathi said on Thursday amid the war in West Asia.

Speaking at an event where INS Sunayna, an offshore patrol vessel, set sail from Mumbai as Indian Ocean Ship (IOS) Sagar, the admiral said competition at sea has no longer remained confined to oil and energy.

Highlights

- » It is now expanding towards resources that will shape future growth - such as rare earth elements, critical minerals, he said.
- » There is significant increase in the marine survey, deep-sea research activity, Tripathi said

It is now expanding towards

resources that will shape future growth - such as rare earth elements, critical minerals, new fishing grounds and even data, he said.

The West Asia crisis began on February 28 after a joint attack by the US and Israel on Iran.

Iran's strikes on its neighbours along with its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz have disrupted the world's energy supplies with effects far beyond West Asia.

"With the conflict in West Asia well into its fifth week,

the disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have caused severe economic impact and energy instability in the region," Tripathi said.

There is significant increase in the marine survey, deep-sea research activity, and Illegal Unreported and Unregulated Fishing (IUU), often encroaching upon the sovereign rights of littoral nations and exploiting gaps in monitoring and enforcement, he said.

Alongside these, threats such as piracy, armed robbery and narco-trafficking

backed by unimpeded access of advanced technology to non-state actors, have also become more complex and challenging to counter, the Navy chief pointed out.

Last year alone, the Indian Ocean Region witnessed a staggering 3,700 maritime incidents of varying nature, the admiral said.

Additionally, narcotics seizures in the region exceeded USD 1 billion USD in 2025, highlighting the persistence and spread of such challenges in the region, he said.

Centre accelerates urban PNG rollout to expand clean energy access

Officials to expand PNG systems across 110 priority zones

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: In a coordinated push to expand clean energy, senior officials from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas chaired a high-level review meeting on Thursday to accelerate the rollout of Piped Natural Gas (PNG) infrastructure in urban India.

The meeting, conducted via video conferencing, brought together state officials, district heads, city managers, and representatives from nearly 200 districts and over 600 urban local bodies. Regulators and

city-level fuel network operators also participated, ensuring broad coordination.

Officials focused on expanding PNG systems across 110 priority zones, emphasizing speedier clearances and tight inter-departmental coordination. States and urban local bodies were given a three-week deadline to submit action plans with targets broken down by ward and specific schedules. The strategy prioritizes neighborhoods with existing pipelines to maximize rapid connectivity.

Authorities noted that 30 lakh households could immediately gain access under existing infrastructure, while another

60 lakh households across cities like Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, and Pune remain potential beneficiaries. States have been advised to establish one-stop hubs and reduce steps for construction approvals. Pipeline layouts are now integrated into the PM Gati Shakti system to streamline planning and execution.

Officials stressed that expanding PNG access is central to India's vision for cleaner, safer, and more energy-efficient cities, and underscored that strong collaboration between all government departments will be key to accelerating progress.

From Page 1

Iran Prez

claim "false and baseless," according to a report on Iranian state television.

Hours before Trump's address, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian posted a lengthy letter in English on his X account appealing to US citizens and stressing that his country had pursued negotiations before the US withdrew from that path. "Exactly which of the American people's interests are truly being served by this war?" he wrote.

Trump has been under growing pressure to end the war that has been pushing up the cost of gasoline, food and other goods. The price of Brent crude, the international standard, is up more than 40 per cent since the start of the war.

Iran fired more missiles at Israel and Gulf Arab states Thursday, demonstrating Tehran's continued ability to strike its neighbours even as the US President claimed the threat from the country was nearly eliminated.

Iran's attacks on Gulf states along with its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz have disrupted the world's energy supplies with effects far beyond the Middle East.

That has proved to be Iran's greatest strategic advantage in the war.

Before the US and Israel started the war on February 28 with strikes on Iran, the waterway was open to traffic and 20 per cent of all traded oil used passed through it.

Iran responded defiantly to Trump's speech, in which the American president claimed US military action had been so decisive that "one of the most powerful countries" is "really no longer a threat".

A spokesman for Iran's military, Lt. Col. Ebrahim Zolfaghari, insisted Thursday that Tehran maintains hidden stockpiles of arms, munitions and production facilities. He said facilities targeted so far by US strikes are "insignificant".

In Lebanon — home to Iran-backed Hezbollah militants who are fighting Israel, which has launched a ground invasion — an Israeli strike killed four people in the south, the Health Ministry said.

More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran during the war, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel. More than two dozen people have died in Gulf states and the occupied West Bank, while 13 US service members have been killed.

More than 1,200 people have been killed and more than 1 million displaced in Lebanon. Ten Israeli soldiers have also died there.

On Thursday, Brent crude, the international standard, rose again and was at USD 108 in spot trading, up about 50 per cent from February 28 when Israel and the US started the war.

Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian has now taken the Trump way, addressing Americans directly. At the outset of the Middle East war, Trump directly addressed Iranians and said: "This is the single greatest chance for the Iranian people to take back their country." In a similar move, Pezeshkian delivered a message that challenges the narrative of war just hours around a major address by Donald Trump.

The letter, released amid escalating conflict, carries a clear and repeated line: Iran is not the enemy of ordinary Americans.

In Seoul, French President Emmanuel Macron said France considers it "unrealistic" to reopen the Strait of Hormuz through a military operation.

"There are people who advocate the idea of the reopening of the

Strait of Hormuz by force, through a military operation, a position that has at times been expressed by the United States," Macron told reporters during a visit to South Korea. "That has never been the option we have chosen, and we consider it unrealistic."

Attack on judicial

from around 3.30 pm on Wednesday and were not allowed to leave till after midnight.

Recording a series of lapses, the bench noted that repeated requests for administrative intervention yielded little response for hours and that even the Chief Secretary could not be contacted. It noted that the Registrar General of the High Court had sought intervention from state administration but no effective steps were taken till 8:30pm. The officers were allegedly denied food and water during the gherao.

The situation improved only after urgent intervention at the highest judicial level late at night.

The court also took serious note of reports that the officers' vehicles were attacked with stones and sticks during their evacuation. Calling it a "brazen attempt" to intimidate judicial officers and obstruct an ongoing court-monitored process, the bench warned that such acts could amount to criminal contempt and would not be tolerated.

Strongly criticising the state administration, the court termed the response of senior officials—including the Chief Secretary, Director General of Police and district authorities—as a "criminal failure". Show-cause notices were issued to them, with directions to appear via video conference on April 6. The court underscored that it would not allow any attempt to create psychological fear among judicial officers discharging their duties.

After the order was dictated, Kishore Datta, Advocate General of West Bengal, submitted that the ECI should not act like an adversary.

The Chief Justice said: "Mr Adv General, now you are compelling us. Unfortunately, in your state, each one of you speaks political language. That is the most unfortunate thing. We have never seen such a polarised state. That even in compliance of court orders, politics is reflected...Do you think we are not aware of who the miscreants are? At least I was monitoring everything till 2 am! Very unfortunate."

CM Mamata

Banerjee on the campaign trail in Murshidabad and Malda on Thursday, Banerjee stated: "This is what Amit Shah wants. He has prepared a blueprint of this conspiracy. This is BJP's gameplan and the Government of India is a party to this. They are provoking you, and then the whole state is being blemished. They want to impose President's rule," stated Banerjee from her campaign rally in Sagardighi, Murshidabad.

Later, addressing a campaign rally in Baishnabnagar in Malda, Banerjee stated: "They have stripped us of all powers. Law and order is not under my jurisdiction anymore. The Election Commission has failed to maintain law and order."

Making an oblique remark on the Congress, CPI(M) and All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMM), Banerjee said: "There are some political outfits that run on BJP's funding. They work as agents to ensure victory for the BJP. They come and provoke the minority community. Where were you

when migrant workers were being harassed and killed in other states? Did you utter a single word on their behalf? Now you are here to divide votes."

She warned the public not to step into any provocation. "If you trust me, stay away from such provocations. Do not get involved in riots. What will be achieved by taking Judges hostage? Maintain peace," urged Banerjee.

The TMC supremo stated that her party did not believe in violence and rioting. "We have nothing to do with this. Whoever is involved should not be spared. Appropriate action has to be taken against all those who are involved, including the masterminds," demanded Banerjee.

She asked people to remain alert in border areas. "They will throw stones at you, and if you step into provocation and retaliate, they will immediately label it 'Hindu-Muslim'. Then they will send the CBI and NIA and arrest you. Till you join BJP, they will not let you in jail. This is what the conspiracy is about," alleged Banerjee.

Banerjee alleged that while genuine residents were being struck off the electoral rolls, names of outsiders were being included as part of the greater conspiracy. "BJP wants to take control of Bengal by force" she said.

"They are striking off names to deport you from the country. If votes are divided and they come to power you will be stripped of your address, house and your rights," cautioned Banerjee.

Taking a dig at Congress, Banerjee said that the BJP would not have come to power in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections had the Congress been a strong party.

"Had they (Congress) been strong, the BJP would not have come to power in the last general elections," Banerjee said.

AAP power

speak in the Rajya Sabha in the future."

The move comes amid Chadha's prolonged silence on matters related to the AAP, and his absence from several public events led by Kejriwal. He becomes the second Rajya Sabha MP of AAP, after Swati Maliwal, to have fallen out with the party leadership.

Once considered a close confidant of Kejriwal and among the youngest MPs in the country, Chadha played a key role in party affairs, particularly in Punjab and during the AAP's tenure in Delhi.

Chadha was abroad for medical reasons when Kejriwal, the then Delhi chief minister, was arrested in connection with the excise policy case in March 2024. He remained away during Kejriwal's nearly six-month incarceration and met him only a few days after his release on September 13, 2024.

More recently, Chadha maintained silence when Kejriwal, former deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia and other AAP leaders were discharged by a Delhi court in the excise case last month. He also missed Kejriwal's press conference and a recent rally at Jantar Mantar following the court's relief.

Party leaders claimed Chadha has been increasingly sidelined from political campaigns and organisational matters of the party in other states, although he has been vocal inside and outside Parliament, raising issues such as high air fares and the condition of gig workers.

The AAP currently has 10 members in the Rajya Sabha, including seven from Punjab and three from Delhi. Thursday's development is significant and raises questions regarding the future of Chadha, once considered AAP's top-rung leader and part of Kejriwal's inner circle, in the party.

Thirty-seven-year-old Chadha has been part of AAP since its

inception. An alumnus of Delhi's Modern School, he is a chartered accountant. Chadha met Kejriwal towards the last leg of the India Against Corruption movement when Kejriwal and others were debating whether or not to start a party. Then 23, Chadha came on board as AAP was formed, and his first political task was to draft the Delhi Lokpal Bill.

Chadha became AAP's face as its national spokesperson and regularly appeared on TV debates. He was appointed AAP's national treasurer at 26. In the 2020 Delhi polls, Chadha was elected from the Rajinder Nagar seat and was appointed the vice-chairman of the Delhi Jal Board. In 2022, he was named AAP's Rajya Sabha pick.

While AAP has not officially spelled out the reason behind what is being seen as Chadha's demotion, buzz about his place in the party has been doing the rounds for the past few months. Chadha also has a Bollywood connection as he married Parineeti Chopra in 2023 in a lavish wedding ceremony.

Session returns

speaking in Rajya Sabha, said the House will meet again soon to consider a key legislation.

"We have certain Bills and important issues, and we have shared this with the opposition also. We are going to have a very important Bill in the next two-three weeks," he said.

The government has been holding back-channel talks with the Opposition to bring at least two bills to implement the women's reservation law and delink delimitation from the Census to increase seats in Lok Sabha from the present 543 to 816.

The issue saw a war of words between the treasury and opposition benches in Rajya Sabha, with Leader of House J P Nadda stressing that the government has the right to decide on the timing when a legislation has to be brought in, while Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge accused the government of being a "bully", and claimed that the BJP of trying to draw political mileage out of the issue of women's reservation.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh, speaking in Rajya Sabha, said that the Opposition has demanded that an all-party meeting should be called once the assembly elections are over, and alleged that the government is pushing the bill despite the Model Code of Conduct being in place in the poll-going states.

"The government has a single-minded objective -- to gain some electoral advantage by passing the bill, violating the Model Code of Conduct... This is wholly objectionable, and all opposition parties want all party meetings to be held after April 29," he said.

Rijiju, however, replied that the government is bound to fulfil its promise given to the women of the country. "What is important is that we have a bound duty, a commitment which the Parliament of India has given to the women of this nation. This has nothing to do with specific state elections. We must take it forward because we have certain limitations when we look at the time scale," he said. "Let us not get into politics over this important issue," the minister said.

Kharge, meanwhile, said that the Congress is in support of reservation for women in the legislature, but the proposed bills are important and have long-term implications. "We all support reservations for women... Don't play games on when and how to bring the Bill," he said.

Rijiju insisted the issue was being politicised by the Opposition, and said, "I am unable to

understand why Congress does not want to attend the meeting".

Sanjay Singh of AAP also accused the government of politicising the issue. NCP (SCP) MP Fauzia Khan questioned if reservations would also be given to women in Rajya Sabha and legislative councils in the states, while RJD's Manoj Jha questioned the government's stand on the demand for reservation for SC, ST and OBCs within the seats reserved for women. Nadda, meanwhile, stressed that it was up to the government to decide the date for the "legislative business". Ramesh also pointed out that when the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam was passed, the government stated it could not be implemented in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls because delimitation was required. The Congress on Wednesday had claimed that the Modi government is proposing to "bulldoze" a bill to increase the size of the Lok Sabha by 50 per cent with the number of seats allocated to each state also to be increased by 50 per cent, and said such a move would "disadvantage" smaller states in the South, Northeast and West.

There was no official word on the Opposition party's claims.

This was the second half of the Budget Session and the House usually adjourns sine die at the end of it. The House normally meets in the Monsoon Session after this.

According to the government calendar, the House was scheduled to adjourn sine die (for an indefinite period) on April 2.

While elections in Puducherry, Assam and Kerala are scheduled for April 9, polls in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and April 29. In Tamil Nadu, polls will be held in a single phase on April 23.

Silent exodus

between 2012 and mid-2018. The CHRI analysis noted that at least 24,570 Indian workers died across six Gulf nations, Bahrain, Oman, Qatar, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE during that six-and-a-half-year period.

In comparison, the latest government data shows that 32,608 Indian workers died in Gulf nations, excluding Bahrain (figures absent in the reply), between 2021 and 2025. This translates to an average of nearly 18 worker deaths every day in the Gulf region alone over the last five years.

Outside the Gulf region, Malaysia and the Maldives also recorded a significant number of labour issues, registering 8,333 and 2,981 complaints, respectively.

Meanwhile, a significant number of complaints originated from Southeast Asian nations despite them reporting few casualties, with grievances spiking sharply in 2024 and 2025.

Myanmar recorded zero worker deaths over the five years but registered 2,548 complaints, including a sharp increase to 1,863 complaints in 2025 alone. Cambodia reported 31 deaths against 2,531 complaints, while Laos saw 11 deaths and 2,416 complaints.

Reports of labour issues have grown steadily over the past five years, peaking in 2025 at 22,479 complaints, up from 16,263 in 2024 and almost double the 11,632 reported in 2021.

According to the ministry's reply, the most frequent difficulties faced by Indian labourers abroad include the delay or non-payment of salaries and end-of-service benefits.

Other common complaints include the unauthorised retention of passports by employers, failure to provide leave, longer working hours without overtime pay, and unemployment due to the sudden closure of companies.

The ministry also noted instances of ill-treatment, the denial of legitimate labour rights and employers' refusal to grant exit visas allowing workers to return to India upon contract completion.

Detailing the steps taken to address the issue, Singh said that the safety and well-being of Indian nationals abroad remain an utmost priority. Upon receiving information about an Indian national in distress, missions and posts immediately contact local foreign affairs ministries, labour departments, and law enforcement agencies in the host country, the minister said.

In addition to providing consular assistance and legal aid, the Government of India has signed overarching Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) on labour and manpower cooperation with several host countries to safeguard the specific interests of Indian workers.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Duty waiver

targeted relief in order to ensure continued availability of critical petrochemical inputs for domestic industry, reduce cost pressures on downstream sectors, and safeguard supply stability in the country," it said.

This will also provide relief to consumers of final products, it added.

The goods on which the customs duty have been exempted include Methanol, Anhydrous ammonia, Toluene, Styrene, Dichloromethane (methylene chloride), Vinyl chloride monomer, Poly butadiene, Styrene butadiene and Unsaturated polyester resins.

Disruption in shipping routes amid the West Asia war has raised concerns over imports of fertiliser, crude oil and natural gas. India is a major importer of fertiliser and petroleum.

Global crude prices have risen by almost 50 per cent since the United States and Israel launched military strikes against Iran on February 28, triggering sweeping retaliation from Tehran.

The government had last week slashed excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 10 a litre as it looked to shield consumers from the impact of rising global crude prices amid the ongoing war, also imposed an export duty of Rs 21.50 per litre on diesel and Rs 29.50 per litre on Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF). Excise duty on petrol has been slashed to Rs 3 a litre, while on diesel it is zero currently.

On Wednesday, the government had allowed SEZ units to sell up to 30 per cent of their export turnover in the domestic market. This is a one-time relief window to ease out the pressure faced by existing units in SEZ due to global trade disruptions.

Asked about the revenue impact of the proposal, Mangal said it is difficult to analyse the revenue implication as it is not known how much the SEZ units will sell in the domestic market.

Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) Director General Ajay Sahai said the import duty exemption is a timely intervention aimed at containing inflationary pressures arising from the prevailing geopolitical situation.

"This measure will also play a crucial role in supporting export competitiveness, as the prices of these key industrial inputs have risen sharply in recent months, significantly increasing production costs for exporters. By easing the input cost burden, the duty reduction will help exporters maintain pricing competitiveness in global markets, honour existing contracts, and mitigate margin pressures during this volatile period," Sahai said.



Piyush Goyal speaks in the Rajya Sabha on Thursday

PTI

NEW DELHI: Parliament on Thursday passed a Bill to amend 784 provisions in 79 central laws for decriminalising and rationalising minor offences to further improve business environment and check harassment of people.

The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, was passed in the Rajya Sabha with a voice vote after Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal replied to a discussion on the legislation.

The Bill was passed by the Lok Sabha on Wednesday.

The minister said the legislation will help citizens and MSMEs. "I believe that there will be no fear in those who make mistakes. There will be fear in those who break the law on purpose. We have tried to bring simplicity by decriminalising all this.

"We have tried to provide protection through adequate civil mechanism. And we have tried to bring swift and proportionate penalties. We have tried to bring swift and proportionate penalties," he said.

Replying to queries and apprehensions raised by various MPs, the minister said comprehensive consultations were held with different government departments, state government and organisations before bringing the amendments.

The Bill proposes to remove imprisonment in 57 provisions and fines in 158 provisions. Also, imprisonment is proposed to be reduced in 17 provisions, and imprisonment and fine are proposed to be converted to a penalty in 113 provisions.

It also proposes 67 amendments under the New Delhi Municipal Council Act, 1994, and the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, to facilitate ease of living.

Refuting suggestions that Drugs and Cosmetics Act is being diluted through the Jan Vishwas Bill, he said the amendment is aimed at only making changes in procedural provisions and compliance.

"We should not go to jail or court for a small mistake in procedural compliance... If someone sells spurious drugs, stocks them, imports them, manufactures them, or distributes them, and if the drugs are not approved by the drug controller... a very strict and severe criminal punishment has been imposed," he said. The minister also rejected Opposition parties' criticism that the Bill has diluted provisions of legislations related to agriculture and allied sectors, saying the changes will instead protect farmers' interest.

Goyal also asserted that the Bill does not compromise on women's safety and said certain changes made in Railway Act are pro-women. The Bill also seeks to carry out 20 amendments under the Motor Vehicles Act, with an aim to provide relaxation for some compliances under the Motor Vehicles Act and resolve legal ambiguities.

AGENCIES



“I am confident that by working together as “Team India” in the emerging crisis situation, the country will successfully overcome this situation. Government’s priorities are to maintain economic and trade stability, ensure energy security, safeguard the interests of citizens, and strengthen industry and supply chains.”
- Narendra Modi



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Don't fall prey of rumours**

**Don't panic and make
unnecessary bookings**

**Appeal to
the Public**

**Get information only
from official sources**

**To ensure the regular and uninterrupted supply and dispatch of L.P.G.,
Control rooms (8:00 AM to 8:00 PM) established at the Chandigarh Headquarter and in all Districts**

S. No.	District Name	Control Room No.	S. No.	District Name	Control Room No.
1	Ambala	0171-2982868	14	Narnaul	01282-251249
2	Bhiwani	01664-242125	15	Panipat	0180-2653850
3	Faridabad	0129-2288245	16	Panchkula	0172-2929353
4	Fatehabad	01667-230773	17	Rewari	01274-225214
5	Gurugram	0124-2868930	18	Rohtak	01262-269895
6	Hansi	01663-254074	19	Sirsa	01666-248422
7	Hisar	01662-233944	20	Sonipat	0130-2242428
8	Jind	01681-245375	21	Yamunanagar	01732-237800
9	Jhajjar	01251-254270	22	Palwal	01275-248911
10	Karnal	0184-2285963	23	Charkhi Dadri	01250-295501
11	Kaithal	01746-224243	Headquarter 1800-180-2087		
12	Kurukshetra	01744-294418			
13	Mewat	01267-274615			

CEC orders FIR, probe by NIA in Malda case

DMK leader Kanimozhi on Thursday took a swipe at the AIADMK over its alliance with the BJP, saying its leader Edappadi K Palaniswami would face the same fate as JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar, and wanted the party "at least" in the opposition. The Lok Sabha MP, addressing a public meeting here for the April 23 polls, claimed it was not a mere Assembly election but a battle between "Keeladi and Nagpur, the headquarters of RSS." She was referring to the Keeladi archaeological excavations in this district, and claimed the findings have proven the heritage value of Tamil, which the "BJP does not want to accept." She said Chief Minister M K Stalin had asked the Centre to accept the report of the findings, which it has not.



EDITORIAL
SHIFTING
SECURITY
ORDER

The possibility of the United States stepping away from the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation is no longer a fringe concern whispered in diplomatic corridors; it is now a live political question with far-reaching consequences. For decades, NATO has been the anchor of Western security, shaping not just military strategy but the broader political stability of Europe and the transatlantic relationship. The mere suggestion that Washington could loosen, or even sever, its commitment marks a profound shift in global power equations. It challenges assumptions that have endured since the end of the Second World War—assumptions built on the idea that collective security, once fractured in the 1930s, would never again be allowed to collapse.

NATO was born out of a hard historical lesson: that disunity invites aggression. Its founding principle—that an attack on one member would be treated as an attack on all—was not simply a military clause but a political deterrent. It worked precisely because it was credible. During the Cold War, that credibility helped prevent direct confrontation between superpowers. In the decades since, it has adapted to new threats, from terrorism to regional instability, while expanding its membership and reach. Its invocation after the attacks of September 11, 2001, demonstrated that the alliance was not a one-way guarantee for Europe but a mutual compact that could be mobilised in defence of the United States itself. To dismiss such an institution as obsolete or ineffective is to overlook both its historical function and its continuing strategic value.

Donald Trump's long-standing scepticism toward NATO is rooted in a transactional view of alliances. His criticism that European members have underinvested in defence is not entirely unfounded; burden-sharing has indeed been uneven. Yet the conclusion he draws—that the alliance is therefore indispensable—reflects a narrower reading of global strategy. Alliances are not balance sheets. They are frameworks that multiply influence, reduce uncertainty and distribute risk. The United States does not merely subsidise European security; it derives strategic depth, forward deployment capabilities and political leverage from its presence across the continent. The network of bases, intelligence cooperation and integrated command structures cannot be replicated overnight, nor can they be replaced without high cost.

More troubling is the context in which this debate is unfolding. Russia's war in Ukraine has underscored the continued relevance of collective defence, even as it exposed the fragility of regional stability. NATO's support has helped prevent the conflict from spilling over into member states, reinforcing deterrence along its eastern flank. At the same time, geopolitical tensions in West Asia and the Indo-Pacific are stretching the attention and resources of major powers. In such an environment, signalling uncertainty about the alliance's future risks emboldens adversaries who have long sought to weaken transatlantic unity. It is no coincidence that Moscow has consistently framed NATO as a threat while simultaneously working to fracture it from within.

The legal and institutional barriers to a formal US withdrawal may slow the process, but they do not eliminate the risk of a functional retreat. A reduction in troop deployments, a weakening of commitments or a reluctance to respond in a crisis could erode the alliance just as effectively as an outright exit. The danger lies not only in what is formally declared, but in what is informally signalled. If allies begin to doubt the reliability of American support, the logic of collective security begins to unravel. Nations may turn inward, pursue independent military capabilities or seek alternative arrangements, leading to a more fragmented and unpredictable security landscape.

Ultimately, the debate over NATO is not just about defence spending or diplomatic grievances; it is about the kind of international order the United States wishes to uphold. For over seven decades, that order has been underwritten by alliances that extend American influence while sharing the burden of global stability. Walking away from that framework would not simply reduce commitments—it would reshape the architecture of power itself. In an era already marked by uncertainty and shifting alignments, such a move would carry consequences far beyond Europe. The strength of NATO has always rested on the belief that its members stand together. Once that belief begins to erode, rebuilding it may prove far more difficult than abandoning it.

RURAL
LENS



KDP RAO

THE WRITER
IS A FORMER
ADDITIONAL CHIEF
SECRETARY OF
CHHATTISGARH

India hosts
over 1,46,000
registered
newspapers
and periodicals,
generating
nearly ₹306
billion in
circulation
revenue
(2014–22). Yet,
despite this scale,
rural coverage
remains limited

The media, which was once confined to newspapers and broadcasting, today, with the digital revolution, has transformed into an indispensable public institution with immense power to influence the thought process of citizens. Revered as the 'fourth estate', it has always played a predominant role in educating people on the accountability of public offices vis-à-vis the rights of the citizenry. However, over time, most media have become primarily urban-centric, focusing mostly on sensational stories surrounding politics, financial scams, celebrities, sports, and promotional narratives. Resultantly, rural news concerning government schemes of development, agricultural activities, drinking water, issues of the rural economy, labour migration issues, etc., often remains unreported. Accountability of the delivery mechanism or that of elected representatives of PRIs differs remarkably in the rural landscape in comparison to urban areas, where the media constantly chases the truth and tries to inform the public. The job of the media as the "watchdog of democracy" remains incomplete when the majority of people who inhabit the backwaters of a country do not become part of the overall growth story. Especially, the voices of vulnerable classes like women, Dalits, Tribes, et al., cannot reach law-enforcing agencies and institutions of governance. Neglect of rural coverage only accentuates the rural-urban divide and disempowers rural populations at large.

The reasons are said to be manifold, including infrastructure, literacy, regulation, economic conditions, and cultural contexts. Additionally, a resource crunch, safety concerns of journalists, and inaccessible terrains make investigative journalism an unenviable enterprise in rural areas. Nonetheless, rural journalists keep struggling to report on issues of public health, drinking water, environmental concerns, education, migration, and more, though the circulation of dailies and journals in rural belts has always been a logistical issue.

Media consumption in India is of a hybrid nature. Reportedly, nearly 47 per cent of rural consumers engage with both traditional (TV, print) and digital (YouTube, Facebook, WhatsApp, short-form video) formats. While the digital revolution helped create an ecosystem of fast communication, it has also brought along extra baggage: misinformation, addictive content, and cultural erosion. A new wave



From drinking water to other social distress, critical issues affecting villages rarely find sustained coverage

called 'citizen journalism', mainly urban-centric and thriving on blogs, social media sites, and podcasts, has flooded the internet with loaded content—more disinformation in character than information. The current panic among the public about fuel and LPG supply on account of the ongoing Gulf war is one such example, as the ground realities stand contrary to it. Absent gatekeeping by professional editors, it has become an inexpensive and convenient avenue for the dissemination of fake news and sectarian views, which poison the innocent minds of peace-loving village folk. Moreover, even as the digital divide disallows hassle-free permeation of news to rural areas, subscriptions raise affordability issues, not to mention cybercrimes and digital arrests.

However, there is a silver lining in the narrative of rural media. Community radio has emerged as one of the most effective tools for rural audiences worldwide, especially in areas marked by poor literacy and inaccessibility. Radio is successful in communicating not only advisories related to farming, healthcare, disaster management, etc., but also in helping local populations ventilate their grievances in local dialects. In Nigeria, South Africa, and Sub-Saharan regions, radio has become a popular medium in addressing development issues and empowering people. In China and parts of Asia (e.g., Thailand), rural broadcasting with state support has been very effective in informing and educating people on agricultural extension and development programmes. In the US, NPR

(National Public Radio) and PBS (Public Broadcasting Service) are major American non-profit public media organisations established through the Public Broadcasting Act of 1967. They are run by public and private funding and serve rural people by educating them on various issues. In Latin America, there are effective community media movements with radio and other information outlets focusing on rural rights and indigenous populations in relation to land issues, environment, and social justice. However, in countries like China and some Latin American nations, public voices are not encouraged, and in extreme cases, the state resorts to crackdowns.

India too has more than 400 community radio broadcasting systems, many of which are run either by marginalised communities or by NGOs. Stations like Radio Bundelkhand, Sangham Radio (Telangana's first all-female station), and others broadcast in local dialects on topics such as farming, women's rights, education, and disaster preparedness, along with participatory content. Similarly, as reported by *Al Jazeera* (9 February 2026), Khabar Lahariya, a women-led newspaper founded in 2002 in Madhya Pradesh (now operating in multiple states and dialects like Bundeli, Awadhi, and Bhojpuri), is run by reporters from weaker sections. It broadcasts investigative stories about corruption, governance failures, caste and gender issues, and rural neglect. A study by Amit Verma, Preeti Singh, et al. (Journal of Communication and Management, 22 March

2025) highlights community radio's role in SDGs (poverty reduction, health, education) across developing countries, with India often cited as a large-scale model alongside African and Latin American examples. However, these broadcasting systems face problems of financial sustainability and cannot afford to scale up.

In spite of heavy odds, rural and vernacular papers all over the world continue to put up a brave front in holding their ground, sometimes even outperforming mainstream publications. They enjoy the trust of readers in rural settings, especially among older demographics, despite the challenges posed by the digital shift. They prove their indispensability in covering stories of development and issues of rural empowerment based on grassroots-level field information, so much so that at times even big media houses cite them in their national-level telecasts. This pattern is observed even in Africa and Asia, where small-time local dailies fill the gaps left by big media houses. However, resource crunch remains an obstacle on their path to growth. For example, according to *The Washington Post*, November 30, 2021, about 2,200—nearly a quarter of American local newspapers—closed between 2005 and 2021. More than 200 counties with no newspaper at all turned into 'news deserts'. The story is not much different in the UK and Europe as well. However, they manage to survive, benefitting from overall infrastructure, unlike their counterparts in the Global South. Moreover, some countries also dole out subsidies to encourage rural media.

According to Statista, India is the largest market for the industry, with over 1,46,000 newspapers and periodicals as of 2023, amounting to a total circulation revenue of ₹306 billion rupees between 2014–22. However, business models overshadow the social responsibility of necessary outreach. Media, as a popular institution of public good, must adhere to principles of inclusivity by reaching out to hitherto neglected areas. There is tremendous scope for rural media to scale up, provided state support is extended through subsidies and generous concessions on par with mainstream media. An inclusive and hybrid ecosystem, with a special place for rural media, is the way forward to empower rural populations, especially vulnerable classes and women, to participate in the democratic process and equitable development.

Views expressed are personal

GREEN
THOUGHTS



NEHA BHATNAGAR

THE WRITER IS
A WETLANDS
CONSERVATION
SPECIALIST AND
IS CURRENTLY
WORKING AS
A RESEARCH
ASSOCIATE AT
THE MOBIUS
FOUNDATION
THINK TANK

A serious
wetland strategy
must combine
basin-level
planning, blue-
green urban
design, stronger
pollution control,
community
stewardship,
scientific
monitoring
and innovative
finance

"To summarise the future of resources and climate, the wall toward which humanity is evidently rushing is a shortage not of minerals and energy, but of food and water."

— Edward O Wilson

Water sustains life, ecosystems, economies, and cultures. Yet, climate change, population growth, rapid urbanisation, and extreme weather events are pushing India toward an unprecedented water crisis. Home to nearly 18 per cent of the global population but possessing only 4 per cent of global freshwater resources, India faces acute hydrological stress. According to the World Resources Institute, 54 per cent of India's land area experiences high to extremely high water stress, placing nearly 600 million people at risk. Per capita water availability is projected to decline to 1,250 cubic metres by 2050, well below the global water scarcity threshold.

Wetlands form the backbone of India's water security architecture. These complex ecosystems regulate hydrological flows, recharge groundwater, purify water, buffer floods, sequester carbon, and sustain biodiversity and livelihoods. India's traditional water management systems—such as kere, cheruvu, baolis, naula, and kuhls—reflect a sophisticated understanding of landscape-scale hydrological interconnections. These decentralised systems once ensured seasonal water security and ecological stability, deeply embedded within cultural and community governance frameworks.

However, colonial-era engineering approaches prioritised large river-valley projects, marginalising indigenous practices and fragmenting natural water systems. This shift weakened tank-based hydrology, eroded community stewardship, and disrupted the delicate linkages



Wetland loss is now directly linked to urban flooding, groundwater decline and rising heat stress

between rivers, lakes, wetlands, and groundwater aquifers. Today, wetlands—often treated as vacant land—remain overlooked despite their role as nature's infrastructure.

India has lost nearly 40 per cent of its wetlands in just three decades, with over half of the remaining wetlands showing ecological degradation. Urban expansion, land reclamation, pollution, agricultural conversion, hydrological modifications, and infrastructure development drive this alarming decline.

Chennai exemplifies this crisis. Between 1988 and 2019, the city lost 85 per cent of its wetlands, severely compromising flood control and groundwater recharge. Once protected by interconnected marshes and tanks, Chennai now alternates between devastating floods and crippling droughts. The catastrophic floods of 2015 and 2023, followed by near-total reservoir depletion in 2019, highlight how wetland loss magnifies climate vulnerability.

Hyderabad has witnessed a 61 per cent decline in lake surface area since 1979. Nearly 40 of its 185 officially recognised lakes have dried up due to encroachment, untreated sewage discharge, and real estate pressure, accelerating groundwater depletion and water insecurity. Gurugram, once

dotted with hundreds of wetlands at the foothills of the Aravallis, has lost nearly 78 per cent of its water bodies between 2007 and 2017, with projections indicating near-total loss by 2025. The disappearance of the Basai marsh, once hosting 20,000 migratory birds, reflects this ecological erasure.

These trends expose the direct relationship between wetland degradation, urban flooding, declining water availability, rising heat stress, and biodiversity collapse. Wetlands are no longer passive victims; their destruction actively worsens climate risks.

India hosts 98 Ramsar Sites—the largest network in Asia and the third largest globally—reflecting strong policy recognition. However, designation alone does not guarantee ecological integrity.

Approximately 47 per cent of Ramsar Sites exhibit "high" to "very high" ecological health. Chilika Lake and Loktak Lake demonstrate effective community governance, adaptive hydrological management, high dissolved oxygen levels, and minimal invasive species presence. These success stories underline the value of participatory conservation and science-based management.

Yet, nearly 40 per cent of Ramsar Sites fall within the "moderate" category, including

Sundarbans and Bhitarkanika, where upstream hydrological disruptions and episodic pollution undermine ecosystem resilience. Alarmingly, about 13 per cent are in "poor" or "very poor" health. Kolleru Lake has lost over 40 per cent of its area to aquaculture, while the East Kolkata Wetlands have experienced more than 50 per cent land loss and dangerously high pollution levels.

This uneven performance reveals a stark reality: legal designation without integrated land-use planning, pollution control, and sustained community engagement fails to secure ecological outcomes.

Restoring India's wetlands requires systemic change grounded in ecological connectivity, inclusive governance, and innovative finance.

First, wetlands must be integrated into national water, urban, agricultural, and climate policies as critical infrastructure. Strengthening institutional coordination through a unified National Wetland Authority would enable basin-scale planning, enforce buffer regulations, and harmonise sectoral mandates.

Second, urban planning must adopt "blue-green infrastructure" frameworks that protect lakes, marshes, and floodplains.

Mandatory rainwater harvesting, wetland retention zoning, and nature-based drainage corridors can significantly reduce flood risk while boosting groundwater recharge.

Third, community stewardship is indispensable. Local knowledge systems, volunteer networks such as Wetland Mitras, and livelihood-linked conservation enterprises can foster long-term ecological guardianship. Wetlands are working landscapes, not wastelands; benefit-sharing mechanisms must ensure equitable participation.

Fourth, science-driven monitoring using satellite data, citizen science platforms, and real-time hydrological indicators must guide adaptive management. Evidence-based governance is essential to track ecosystem health and course-correct interventions.

Finally, innovative financing holds transformative potential. Carbon finance, Payments for Ecosystem Services (PES), green bonds, and public-private partnerships can mobilise large-scale restoration funding. Wetlands store substantial carbon while delivering climate adaptation benefits—making them ideal candidates for high-integrity carbon markets. If anchored in strong governance and community ownership, carbon finance can realign conservation with economic incentives.

India stands at a decisive crossroads. As climate extremes intensify and water stress deepens, wetlands offer one of the most powerful, cost-effective, and resilient solutions. Protecting these water-logged landscapes is not merely an ecological necessity—it is central to securing food systems, urban resilience, biodiversity conservation, and climate adaptation. The opportunity is profound, but the cost of inaction is irreversible. Reclaiming India's wetlands is, ultimately, about reclaiming the nation's water future.

Views expressed are personal

‘MUST CONTINUOUSLY UPDATE INDIA’S GOVERNANCE MACHINERY’

‘Put citizens first, keep governance evolving’: PM to public servants

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday stressed the need to continuously update governance with the rapidly changing times to ensure ease of living for citizens.

Highlighting that the core mantra driving the country’s administration today is “Nagrik Devo Bhava” (treating citizens as supreme), he said that public service is being reoriented to be more capable and sensitive to the needs of citizens.

“Governance is now being given a new identity by making it truly citizen-centric,” Modi said in a video message at the launch of ‘Sadhana Saptah’.

The prime minister said that governance must be the benchmark for improving ease of living and quality of life for citizens, and urged public servants to learn something new every day. “Our governance should ensure that the quality



PM Narendra Modi being felicitated by Andhra Pradesh HRD Minister Nara Lokesh during a meeting PTI

of life of citizens improves day by day. This is our true benchmark,” he asserted.

Calling for a fundamental shift in administrative culture, Modi pointed out that the old system placed excessive emphasis on being an ‘officer’, whereas the country’s focus today is firmly on the spirit of duty.

“Before every decision, when you think about what

your duty demands, the impact of your decisions will automatically multiply many times over,” he said, addressing public servants.

India is advancing swiftly amidst fast-changing global systems, and it must continuously update its governance machinery, the prime minister said.

Reminding public servants

Highlights

- » Modi pointed out that the old system placed excessive emphasis on being an ‘officer’, whereas the country’s focus today is firmly on the spirit of duty
- » “Governance is now being given a new identity by making it truly citizen-centric,” Modi said in a video message at the launch of ‘Sadhana Saptah’
- » The PM said that governance must be the benchmark for improving ease of living and quality of life for citizens

Addressing India’s federal structure, Modi emphasised that the nation’s success is a collective success of all its states.

He also mentioned the dismantling of outdated categorisations such as “forward states,” “backward states,” and “BIMARU states,” advocating for bridging the gaps between states through coordinated efforts.

“We have to break silos and move forward with better coordination, shared understanding and a whole-of-government approach; only then will every mission succeed,” the prime minister said.

Modi linked the necessity for rapid economic growth, modern infrastructure, technology adoption, and a large skilled workforce to the broader vision of a developed India (Viksit Bharat), asserting that public institutions and servants play a critical role in achieving these goals.

that for the common citizen, the local government office is the face of the entire government, Modi said that the working style and behaviour of officials directly shape public trust in democracy and constitutional institutions. “Whatever we do, at whatever level, we must safeguard that trust; it is the foundation of our democracy,” the prime minister said.

Akhilesh says EC is biased, attacks BJP over governance and farmers’ issues

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday accused the Election Commission of acting in favour of the BJP in poll-bound states such as West Bengal and Assam.

Speaking to reporters at the party headquarters, he claimed that several senior officials, including the Director General of Police, had been removed in West Bengal, a move he said was not seen during the 2022 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections.

He alleged that despite complaints of irregularities during by-elections in Uttar Pradesh, no action has been taken against the officials involved. He said neither the Election Commission nor the state government

He alleged that despite complaints of irregularities during by-elections in UP

had acted on these complaints so far.

Targeting the BJP, Yadav said that once elections conclude in West Bengal and Assam, BJP leaders will turn their attention to Uttar Pradesh.

He, however, expressed confidence that a government led by PDA would be formed in the state. Referring to the BJP’s promise of better days, he said people would see relief once the party is voted out of power in

Uttar Pradesh.

Commenting on the resignation of IAS officer Rinku Singh Rahi, Yadav alleged that corruption in the state had reached alarming levels. He said such developments indicate growing dissatisfaction within the administrative system and claimed that officials are now inclined towards supporting a change in government.

Yadav also blamed BJP leaders for the ongoing LPG cylinder shortage in the state, alleging that the situation had been worsened deliberately. Raising concerns about farmers, he said that despite promises to double their income, cultivators continue to face distress and are not receiving fair prices for their produce.

Pb CM pins Chandigarh BJP office attack on Centre

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday firmly held the Centre accountable for the attack outside the BJP office in Chandigarh, asserting that a Union Territory under central control cannot become a convenient ground for political blame-shifting.

Making it clear that responsibility lies squarely with the Union government, he stated that if attempts are being made to pin the incident on him, then the Centre should hand over Chandigarh to the Punjab government instead of evading its own duty.

At the same time, CM Mann drew a sharp contrast between governance models, highlighting how the AAP government is reducing the finan-



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann during a press conference

MPOST

cial burden on people while the Congress-led government in Himachal Pradesh is imposing unjust entry taxes on the public, calling the move anti-people and vowing strong opposition at every level.

Reaffirming his government’s commitment to farmers, the CM underscored that Punjab will continue to strongly take up the demands of Aarthiyas with the Union Government, ensuring seamless procurement and stand-

ing firmly with the farming community.

“Though Chandigarh is administered by the Governor of Punjab, for everything that happens in the Union Territory right from farmers agitation, agitation in Panjab University (PU) or others, the BJP loves to blame me,” he said, adding, “It should refrain from baseless and irrelevant statements on this issue as the area is under the jurisdiction of the Administrator of Union Territory.”

Mann opens hospital in Cheema

CHANDIGARH: Ensuring superior health facilities in villages, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday inaugurated the Sant Attar Singh Ji Maharaj Hospital at Cheema village. The 30-bedded facility built at a cost of Rs 11.70 crore begins serving tens of thousands across the region. The CM emphasised that the hospital will benefit around 50,000 people across 15 villages, while also strengthening access to affordable and quality treatment for nearly 35,000–40,000 residents in nearby areas. MPOST

Chabahar at crossroads: India completes funding amid sanctions shadow

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Thursday confirmed that India has completed its financial commitment to the strategic Chabahar Port project in Iran. The government also stated that it continues to engage stakeholders on the port’s future amid evolving geopolitical dynamics and uncertainties linked to sanctions.

In response to an unstarred question in the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh said India had allocated Rs 400 crore for Chabahar Port’s development in the 2025–26 financial year, with the final tranche disbursed in August

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal added that the US sanctions waiver for Chabahar Port remains valid until April 26, 2026

last year. Under the contract between India Ports Global Limited and Iran’s Ports and Maritime Organisation, India had pledged a total of USD 120 million for port equipment. No additional funds were allocated in the 2026–27 Union Budget, as no further financial requirement exists at this stage. MEA spokesperson

Randhir Jaiswal added that the US sanctions waiver for Chabahar Port remains valid until April 26, 2026. He said India is actively engaging with all relevant stakeholders to address implications arising from the evolving situation.

Strategically, Chabahar Port plays a vital role in enhancing India’s connectivity to Afghanistan and Central Asia, bypassing Pakistan. However, the project continues to operate under the shadow of US sanctions on Iran. Its future trajectory will depend on geopolitical developments, particularly the sanctions regime and regional stability, even as India emphasizes the port’s long-term strategic and economic significance.

Haryana CM Saini asserts BJP is only option for ‘distressed’ farmers & traders of Punjab

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: A delegation of the Punjab Arhtiya (commission agents) Association met Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini at his Sant Kabir Kutir residence to discuss issues concerning arhtiyas in Punjab.

The delegation informed the Chief Minister that around 40,000 arhtiyas, nearly 1.25 lakh accountants (munims), and 6–7 lakh workers are associated with this system in Punjab.

They said the ongoing strike in Punjab is affecting not only business activities but also the livelihoods of lakhs of families. Despite talks with the government, no resolution has been reached. The delegation added



PM Narendra Modi being felicitated by Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday PTI

that during the current crop procurement season, farmers, labourers, and arhtiyas are all facing hardships.

Expressing concern, the CM said he had visited Punjab multiple times and observed widespread distress among farmers, traders, and labourers. He criticized the Aam Aadmi Party gov-

ernment for failing to address these problems, claiming its policies have weakened Punjab’s economy and pushed the state towards financial strain.

Meanwhile, Saini has demonstrated prompt administrative action by directing concrete steps to implement budget announcements within just one month of presenting the state budget. He instructed concerned departments to prepare detailed action plans to ensure timely and effective execution.

The CM reviewed progress with officials from departments including Energy, Health, Revenue, Excise and Taxation, Cooperation, Development and Panchayats, Agriculture, Animal Husbandry, Fisheries.

Kanpur kidney racket: Donors paid Rs 5L, patients charged Rs 80L in multi-state organ trade

Similar rackets have been exposed in Kanpur in the past, including a major case in 2019

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

KANPUR: A kidney transplant racket busted in Kanpur has uncovered a sprawling criminal network that preyed on poverty, desperation and critically ill patients, with links stretching across several states and even beyond India’s borders.

What began as a complaint over underpayment to a donor quickly unravelled into a well-organised syndicate involving middlemen, private hospitals and suspected involvement of medical professionals. Investigators said the operation extended beyond Uttar Pradesh, indicating a coordinated inter-state network.

At the centre of the case is Ayush, a resident of Samastipur in Bihar who had been living in Meerut. Facing financial hardship, he was allegedly lured through intermediaries and messaging platforms such as Telegram with a promise of Rs 10 lakh in exchange for donating his kidney.

Ayush was brought to Kanpur where the deal was finalised

Highlights

- » What began as a complaint over underpayment to a donor quickly unravelled into a well-organised syndicate involving middlemen, private hospitals and suspected involvement of medical professionals
- » Investigators said the operation extended beyond Uttar Pradesh,

indicating a coordinated inter-state network

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before he was taken to a private hospital in Keshavpuram for surgery. After the transplant, he was allegedly paid significantly less than the agreed amount. The payment dispute prompted him to alert the police, leading to the exposure of the racket.

Officials said the breakthrough followed weeks of surveillance. For nearly three weeks, police and the Special Operations Group had been tracking suspicious activities linked to

illegal transplants. Acting on specific inputs, a joint team of the Crime Branch, SOG and the health department conducted coordinated raids on three hospitals on March 30.

The first raid targeted the hospital where the transplant surgery was carried out. Teams then moved to a facility in Kalyanpur where the recipient, identified as Parul Tomar, had been admitted, and later to a hospital on Panki Road where Ayush was

being kept.

Investigators found glaring irregularities across all locations, including absence of valid documentation, missing transplant records and lack of satisfactory explanations from hospital authorities.

The probe revealed that immediately after surgery, donors and recipients were shifted to different hospitals to avoid detection. This separation ensured that scrutiny at one facility would not expose the entire chain.

Parul Tomar had reportedly been admitted under the pretext of gallbladder surgery. Hospital staff are said to have followed instructions from a person posing as a doctor over the phone without verifying credentials. Ayush, meanwhile, was kept in a small room at another hospital without proper medical supervision and was dependent only on intravenous fluids despite his deteriorating condition.

Officials said the racket followed a clear pattern. Economically vulnerable individuals were targeted as donors

and promised large sums, while patients with kidney failure were offered quick transplants, bypassing long waiting periods.

The financial structure of the network was highly exploitative. Donors were promised between Rs 8 lakh and Rs 10 lakh but were often paid only Rs 4 lakh to Rs 5 lakh. In contrast, recipients were charged between Rs 60 lakh and Rs 80 lakh.

Middlemen played a central role in coordinating the operation. One of the key accused, Shivam Agarwal alias Shubham, allegedly posed as a medical professional to gain trust, connect donors with recipients and arrange hospital tie-ups.

Police said he had access to major hospitals and specifically targeted patients seeking urgent treatment. Investigators have also found that teams of doctors were allegedly brought in from cities such as Delhi and Lucknow to carry out surgeries, raising serious questions about the role of trained medical professionals. Authorities are examining whether they were knowingly involved.

India joins 60-nation effort to reopen Strait of Hormuz

Looks to ensure energy and maritime security

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India on Thursday raised concern over maritime security and energy stability amid the ongoing global tensions in West Asia. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri voiced the country’s concern while participating in a high-level meeting convened by the United Kingdom virtually. More than 60 countries participated in the meeting.

In his remarks at the meeting, Misri noted the importance of the principles of freedom of navigation and unimpeded transit through international waterways. He emphasised the impact of the crisis on India’s energy security and the fact that India remains the only country to have lost mariners in attacks on merchant shipping in the Gulf. He also underlined that the way out of the crisis consisted of de-escalation and a return to the path of diplomacy and dialogue among all concerned

Over the past few days, six Indian ships have successfully crossed the Strait

parties, according to a statement by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

At the invitation of the UK, India joined the meeting to explore ways to reopen the vital Strait of Hormuz, whose closure has sent oil prices spiralling, the MEA said.

Confirming India’s participation, the MEA’s official spokesperson, Randhir Jaiswal, had said earlier in the day that the meeting would be attended virtually by Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri.

“The UK side has invited several countries, which also include India, for talks on the Strait of Hormuz. From our side, the foreign secretary is attending the meeting this eve-

ning,” Jaiswal had said.

“We are in touch with Iran and other countries there to see how best we can get unimpeded transit and safe transit for our ships, which are carrying products including LPG, LNG and other products. Through this conversation that we have had over the last several days, we have had six Indian ships which have been able to safely cross the Strait of Hormuz, and we continue to be in touch with relevant parties,” the spokesperson explained.

The Strait of Hormuz is critical to the world economy because 20% of global energy supplies pass through the narrow waterway, which has been closed by Iran following the attacks on it by Israel and the US. The stakes are even higher for India, because roughly 40% of the oil, 50% of the liquefied natural gas (LNG), and over 80% of the liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) that the country imports flow through this route.

Adani offers prayers at Ayodhya Temple

BP SINGH

AYODHYA: Leading industrialist Gautam Adani visited Ayodhya on Thursday and offered prayers at the Ram Temple with his family, describing the experience as deeply moving and a matter of great pride.

Adani arrived at Maharishi Valmiki International Airport, where he was welcomed by administrative officials before heading straight to the temple for darshan.

After offering prayers, he said the visit held immense emotional significance for him and his family. He noted that the temple stands not only as a place of devotion but also as a reflection of India’s cultural heritage, unity and confidence.

“Visiting Ayodhya and seeking the blessings of Lord Ram is an emotional and proud moment for me and my family. This temple represents not only devotion but also the spirit of India’s cultural heritage and unity. The ideals of Lord Ram inspire us to walk on the path of truth and duty. I pray that his blessings remain with all of us and that the country continues to move forward on the path of progress,” he said.

He added that the Adani Foundation would provide all possible support to preserve the Gurukul tradition in contemporary times.

MP Congress legislator gets 3-year jail in bank fraud case

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

NEW DELHI: Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti from Madhya Pradesh was on Thursday sentenced to three years’ imprisonment by a Delhi court in connection with a bank fraud case.

Bharti, who represents the Datia Assembly constituency and defeated senior BJP heavyweight Dr Narottam Mishra, the then Home Minister in the Shivraj Singh Chouhan regime, in the 2023 polls, was convicted along with his aide Raghuvver Sharan Prajapati, a former employee of the Zila Sahkari Krishi Gramin Vikas Bank, Datia.

The Rouse Avenue Court in Delhi awarded both the convicts three-year jail terms in a case involving cheating and forgery of bank records to obtain illegal interest payments between 1998 and 2011. Special Judge Dig Vinay Singh also imposed a fine of Rs 1 lakh on Bharti and Rs 1.5 lakh on Prajapati, directing that the amount be used as compensation for the bank.

According to the prosecution, Bharti’s late mother had deposited Rs 10 lakh in 1998 in the name of a family-run trust as a fixed deposit for three years at an interest rate of 13.5 per cent. However, the



accused allegedly tampered with bank records using correction fluid and overwriting to extend the deposit period by 10 to 15 years, enabling continued withdrawal of interest till 2011 despite falling market rates. The trust is alleged to have illegally withdrawn around Rs 18.5 lakh as interest.

The court held that Bharti, who was chairman of the bank during the relevant period, used his position to influence employees and facilitate unauthorised payments. Both accused were convicted of criminal conspiracy, cheating, forgery and use of forged documents.

The case, registered in Datia in 2015, was transferred to Delhi by the Supreme Court in October last year following concerns over witness intimidation.

During sentencing, the prosecution sought maximum punishment, citing breach of public trust, while the defence pleaded for leniency, citing Bharti’s public responsibilities and health issues.

INTERNATIONAL BOOKER PRIZE 2026

Indian-origin translator Padma Viswanathan shortlisted

NEW DELHI: Padma Viswanathan, a Canadian-American writer of Indian-origin, has made it to the 2026 International Booker Prize shortlist as the English translator of a Portuguese language novella. "On Earth As It Is Beneath" by Brazilian author Ana Paula Maia, described by judges as a "brutal, haunting and hypnotic novella set in a remote

Brazilian penal colony, where the boundaries between justice and cruelty collapse", is among the six worldwide contenders for the coveted literary honour. The annual prize worth GBP 50,000, divided equally between the author and translator, was won last year by Kannada writer-activist Banu Mushtaq and translator Deepa Bhashti for the short story col-



Padma Viswanathan

lection "Heart Lamp". Each shortlisted title guarantees a prize of GBP 5,000 -- also

split 50-50 between the book's author and English translator. "What struck us most is how spare, unflinching, uncompromising and relentless it is. Maia builds an entire moral universe out of very little: a remote prison, a handful of men, and the rituals of punishment that govern their lives. "The novel reads almost like a dark fable about power,

where brutality is ordinary and civilisation feels frighteningly thin," the judging panel, which also include award-winning Indian novelist and columnist Nilanjana S. Roy, said of the work translated by US-based Viswanathan. The 58-year-old professor of creative writing at the University of Arkansas-Fayetteville is an accomplished playwright

and author, whose novels have been published in eight countries. The list, announced on Tuesday, is dominated by women, with five of the six authors and four of the six translators being female. The authors and translators represent eight countries -- Brazil, Bulgaria, Canada, France, Germany, Taiwan, the UK and the United States. AGENCIES

Trump says Bondi is out as attorney general

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump has said that Pam Bondi is out as his attorney general. This ends the contentious tenure of a loyalist who upended the Justice Department's culture of independence from the White House, oversaw large-scale firings of career employees and moved aggressively to investigate the Republican president's perceived enemies.



US President Donald Trump

The announcement follows months of scrutiny over the Justice Department's handling of files related to Jeffrey Epstein's sex trafficking investigation that made Bondi the target of angry conservatives even with her close relationship with Trump. She also struggled to satisfy Trump's demands to prosecute his political rivals, with multiple investigations rejected by judges or grand juries.

The former Florida attorney general came into office last year pledging that she would not play politics with the Justice Department, but she quickly started investigations of Trump foes, sparking an outcry that the law enforcement agency was being wielded as a tool of revenge to advance

the president's political and personal agenda.

Bondi ushered in a period of intense turmoil at the department that included the firings of career prosecutors deemed insufficiently loyal to Trump and the resignations of hundreds of other employees.

Her departure continues a trend of Justice Department upheaval that has defined Trump's presidency as multiple attorneys general across his two terms have either been pushed out or resigned after proving unwilling or unable to meet his demands for the position. Bondi rejected accusations that she politicised the Justice Department and said her mission was to restore the institution's credibility after overreach by President Joe Biden's Democratic administration with two federal criminal cases against Trump. AGENCIES

WEST ASIA CRISIS

Putin, Saudi Crown Price call for stepped-up diplomacy

MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin and Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman on Thursday called for a rapid cessation of hostilities and the intensification of political and diplomatic efforts for a long-term settlement of the West Asia conflict.

The two held a telephonic conversation during which a "comprehensive review of issues related to the crisis in the Middle East was conducted," the Kremlin said.

Both sides expressed "serious concern" about the deteriorating military and political situation in the region, civilian casualties, and the destruction of strategically important infrastructure, it said. They emphasised the need for a "rapid cessation of hostilities and the intensification of political

and diplomatic efforts to achieve a long-term settlement of the conflict, with due regard for the legitimate interests of all parties," the Kremlin readout said. The two leaders also underlined the importance of joint work of Russia and Saudi Arabia in the "OPEC Plus" format to stabilise the global oil market destabilised due to closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

The US and Israel jointly attacked Iran on February 28, killing Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several top commanders.

The retaliation by the Islamic Republic extended the war to the entire Gulf region. The conflict has taken a major toll on energy supply chains, especially across the Strait of Hormuz. AGENCIES

World Briefs

JEE EXAM COMMENCES IN SAUDI ARABIA

DUBAI: The Joint Entrance Examination (JEE-Main) commenced in Saudi Arabia on Thursday, the Indian mission said. The engineering entrance assessment is conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA). "JEE (Main) 2026 examinations have officially commenced today in Saudi Arabia, with arrangements in place to ensure a smooth and seamless conduct of the exams," the Indian Embassy in Riyadh said in a post on X. It extended full support to the NTA and the designated Examination Centre to "facilitate the process and assist the candidates throughout". "Wishing all students the very best for their exams and great success ahead!" it said.

NEPAL TO OPERATE SPECIAL FLIGHTS TO BRING BACK ITS NATIONALS IN GULF

KATHMANDU: Nepal's national flag carrier will operate special flights for three days starting Friday to bring back its nationals stranded in the Gulf countries due to the ongoing war in the region. According to a statement issued by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, a Nepal Airlines flight will depart for Dubai on Friday at 23:15 (local time) and return to Kathmandu early Saturday. On the morning of April 5, a flight will leave for Dammam in Saudi Arabia and return to Kathmandu at noon on the same day. The decision was taken following a meeting on Tuesday attended by senior officials from the Minister for Foreign Affairs, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, the CAAN, and Nepal Airlines.

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Harish Kumar S/o Chandar Prakash R/o H.No. 357, Gali No. 2, Shakti Vihar, Mithapur, Badarpur, New Delhi-110044 do hereby declare that my daughter name is Sonika I have changed my daughter name from Sonika to Sonika Gangal, Hereafter be called. That my daughter name Sonika and Sonika Gangal is same and one person.

COURT NOTICE (U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC) IN THE COURT OF Sh. Sanjay SDJM Samalkha Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division), Samalkha Kavite Devi Vs. State of Haryana CNR No. HRPAA0-000233-2023 Next Date 24-04-2026 CS/179/2023

PUBLICATION ISSUED TO: Defendant-Shamina Spouse: :-Mehardeen S/o Hanif, C/o Manglu, Durga Colony, VPO BApoli. Additional Address- C/o Nalwa Colony, VPO BApoli, Bapoli In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 24-04-2026 at 10:00 am. For details login to https://highcourtcdh.gov.in/?mod= district notice & district = Panipat Sd/- Sh. Sanjay Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division), SDJM Dated 16.03-2026 Samalkha

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida 201301 (U.P.) Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firm for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & https://etender.up.nic.in. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/ amendments & corrigendum etc.

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the Work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
1	54/DGM/SM (WC-3) / 2025-26	D/o Village (M/o Building (Jatav Bhawan) in Village Sadarpur, Noida	5.87
2	55/DGM/SM (WC-3) / 2025-26	M/o Building (C/o Toilet nearby V.D.S. Market Sector-51) Noida	10.37
3	63/DGM/SM (WC-3) / 2025-26	M/o Building (C/o 2 nos. Toilet near Covid Hospital in Sector-39), Noida.	23.73
4	07/GM/SM (E&M-III)/2025-26	Annual Operation and routine Maintenance of Electrical Equipment such as L.T. Pannel, CCTV Camera, ISTMS Equipment at Command Control Centre Sector-94, Noida.	14.28

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 06.04.2026 to 20.04.2026 up to 5:00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 21.04.2026 at 11:00 AM.

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the Work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
5.	31/SM(WC-4)/ET/ 2025-26	D/o & M/o Village (R/o damaged Approach road of Chhajarsi Shamshan Ghat), Noida.	22.57

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 06.04.2026 to 13.04.2026 up to 5:00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 15.04.2026 at 11:00 AM.

General Manager (Civil) Noida

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS! IMPORTANT INFORMATION

RUN OF MORE SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS -2026 In order to clear extra rush of passengers during the upcoming Summer season, Railways have decided to run the following additional Summer Special Trains as per details given below :

04081/04082 New Delhi - Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra - 80 Trips - New Delhi Reserved Special Express (Tri-Weekly)

Train No. 04081	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04082	ARR.	DEP.
--	23:45	--	New Delhi	--	10:00	--
12:00	--	Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra	--	21:00	--	

Days of run :- 04081 Ex. New Delhi from 15.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Monday, Wednesday, Friday) and 04082 Ex. Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra from 16.04.2026 to 16.07.2026 (Tuesday, Thursday, Saturday).

Accommodation : 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Panipat, Kurukshetra Jn. Ambala Cantt., Ludhiana Jn., Jalandhar Cantt., Pathankot Cantt., Jammu Tawi & Martyr Captain Tushar Mahajan Stations.

04610/04609 Amritsar - Barauni - Amritsar - 26 Trips Reserved Special Express (Weekly)

Train No. 04610	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04609	ARR.	DEP.
--	20:10	--	Amritsar	--	13:15	--
02:10	--	Barauni	--	05:05	--	

Days of run :- 04610 Ex. Amritsar from 19.04.2026 to 12.07.2026 (Sunday) and 04609 Ex. Barauni from 21.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (Tuesday).

Accommodation : 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Beas, Jalandhar City, Phagwara, Dhandari Kalan, Sirhind, Rajpura, Ambala Cantt., Yamanunagar Jagadhri, Saharanpur, Moradabad, Bareilly, Sitapur, Gonda, Gorakhpur, Siwan, Chhapra, Sonpur, Hajipur & Shahpur Patoree Stations.

04314/04313 Yog Nagari Rishikesh - Muzaffarpur - 52 Trips Nagari Rishikesh Reserved Special Express (Bi-weekly)

Train No. 04314	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04313	ARR.	DEP.
--	15:20	--	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	--	11:15	--
11:20	--	Muzaffarpur	--	14:00	--	

Days of run :- 04314 Ex. Yog Nagari Rishikesh from 16.04.2026 to 12.07.2026 (Thursday & Sunday) and 04313 Ex. Muzaffarpur from 17.04.2026 to 13.07.2026 (Friday & Monday).

Accommodation : 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Haridwar, Moradabad, Bareilly, Shahjehanpur, Sitapur, Gonda, Basti, Gorakhpur, Siwan, Chhapra & Hajipur Stations.

04316/04315 Yog Nagari Rishikesh - Gorakhpur - 26 Trips Nagari Rishikesh Reserved Special Express (Weekly)

Train No. 04316	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04315	ARR.	DEP.
--	15:20	--	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	--	01:30	--
06:20	--	Gorakhpur	--	09:00	--	

Days of run :- 04316 Ex. Yog Nagari Rishikesh from 21.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (Tuesday) and 04315 Ex. Gorakhpur from 22.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Wednesday).

Accommodation : 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Haridwar, Moradabad, Bareilly, Shahjehanpur, Sitapur, Gonda & Basti Stations.

For detailed information regarding stoppages and timings of above trains, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website: www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

RailMadad Helpline No. 139

Visit RailMadad website:- www.railmadad.indianrailways.gov.in

Download RailMadad app.

01705/01706 Jabalpur - Ayodhya Dham - 26 Trips - Jabalpur Summer Special Express (Weekly)

Train No. 01705	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 01706	ARR.	DEP.
--	19:40	--	Jabalpur	--	06:45	--
07:05	07:15	Varanasi	--	17:10	17:20	
11:25	--	Ayodhya Dham	--	13:30	--	

Days of run :- 01705 Ex. Jabalpur from 21.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (Tuesday) and 01706 Ex. Ayodhya Dham from 22.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Wednesday).

Accommodation : 1st AC, 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Sihora road, Katni, Maihar, Satna, Manikpur, Prayagraj Chheoki, Mirzapur & Jaunpur Stations.

04512/04511 Chandigarh-Patna Jn.-Chandigarh - 26 Trips Reserved Special Express (Weekly)

Train No. 04512	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04511	ARR.	DEP.
--	23:35	--	Chandigarh	--	21:40	--
21:15	--	Patna Jn.	--	23:15	--	

Days of run :- 04512 Ex. Chandigarh from 16.04.2026 to 09.07.2026 (Thursday) and 04511 Ex. Patna Jn. from 17.04.2026 to 10.07.2026 (Friday).

Accommodation : 3rd AC, 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC Economy, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Ambala Cantt., Saharanpur, Roorkee, Moradabad, Bareilly, Shahjehanpur, Hardoi, Alamnagar, Utratlita, Sultanpur, Varanasi, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya, Buxar, Ara & Danapur Stations.

04520/04519 Bathinda-Varanasi-Bathinda - 54 Trips Reserved Special Express (Bi-Weekly)

Train No. 04520	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04519	ARR.	DEP.
--	20:50	--	Bathinda	--	17:00	--
17:30	--	Varanasi	--	20:40	--	

Days of run :- 04520 Ex. Bathinda from 15.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Wednesday & Saturday) and 04519 Ex. Varanasi from 16.04.2026 to 16.07.2026 (Thursday & Sunday).

Accommodation : 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Rampura Phul, Barnala, Dhuri, Patiala, Rajpura, Ambala Cantt., Yamanunagar Jagadhri, Saharanpur, Najibabad, Moradabad, Bareilly, Alamnagar, Utratlita, Raebareilly & Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh Stations.

04312/04311 Yog Nagari Rishikesh-Kolkata - 26 Trips Nagari Rishikesh Reserved Special Express (Weekly)

Train No. 04312	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04311	ARR.	DEP.
--	22:20	--	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	--	23:30	--
08:00	--	Kolkata	--	13:55	--	

Days of run :- 04312 Ex. Yog Nagari Rishikesh from 17.04.2026 to 10.07.2026 (Friday) and 04311 Ex. Kolkata from 19.04.2026 to 12.07.2026 (Sunday).

Accommodation : 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General. Stoppages : Haridwar, Moradabad, Bareilly, Shahjehanpur, Alam Nagar, Utratlita, Raebareilly, Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh, Varanasi, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya, Bhabua Road, Sasaram, Dehri On Son, Anugrah Narayan Road, Gaya, Koderma, Parasnath, NSC Bose Gomoh, Dhanbad, Asansol, Durgapur, Bardhaman, Bandel & Naihati Stations.

Extension of 04217/04218 Varanasi - Lucknow - Varanasi un-reserved Special Express on existing path.

Train no.	From-To	Earlier Notified Up to	Extended Up to
04217	Varanasi-Lucknow	31.05.26	01.06.26 to 15.07.26
04218	Lucknow-Varanasi	31.05.26	01.06.26 to 15.07.26

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क्र./महा./स्टोर/2026/850 उज्जैन, दिनांक : 01.04.2026

निविदा विज्ञप्ति (खाद्यान्न सामग्री) द्वितीय

Tender ID : 2026_MMPSU_495973_1

श्री महाकालेश्वर मंदिर प्रबंध समिति द्वारा संचालित लड्डू प्रसाद, श्री अन्न लड्डू प्रसाद, वैदिक शोध संस्थान, नि:शुल्क अन्नक्षेत्र, नित्यभोग एवं अन्य आयोजित कार्यक्रमों में वर्ष 2026-27 में खाद्यान्न सामग्री (किराना) प्रदाय करने हेतु संबंधित व्यवसायीयों से ई-टेंडर के माध्यम से ऑनलाइन बids आमंत्रित की जाती है :- कार्य का नाम : श्री महाकालेश्वर मंदिर में खाद्यान्न (किराना) सामग्री प्रदाय करने हेतु

कार्य की अनुमानित लागत : ₹. 20,00,00,000/- (बीस करोड़)
निविदा की प्रतिभूति राशि : ₹. 40,00,000/- (चालीस लाख)
टेंडर डाक्यूमेंट की लागत : ₹. 5000/- (पांच हजार)
टेंडर डाक्यूमेंट क्रय करने एवं बीड प्रस्तुत करने की दिनांक ई-टेंडरिंग पोर्टल https://mpenders.gov.in पर Tender ID : 2026_MMPSU_495973_1 देखी जा सकती है। पोर्टल में उल्लेखित दिनांक अनुसार कार्यवाही सुनिश्चित करें।
म.प्र. माध्यम/125166/2026 उप प्रशासक एवं डिप्टी कलेक्टर

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, MINOR IRRIGATION DIVISION, SAHIBGANJ

e-Procurement Tender Notice Two Envelope System

Short Re. E-Tender Reference No:- WRD/MID/SAHIBGANJ/ F2-01/2026-27 Date:- 01.04.2026

1	Name of Work:	Renovation of Bakudih Medium Irrigation Scheme, Block: Taljhari, District- Sahibganj
2	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	12395392.00
3	Time of Completion	11 Months
4	Date of Publication of E-Tender on website	Date: 09.04.2026 (www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in)
5	Last Date/Time for Submission of E-Tender BID's	Date: 20.04.2026 Time: 05:00 PM
6	Last date for online Submission of E-Tender Fee and EMD	Last Date:- 20.04.2026 Time: 05:00 PM Rs. 10000.00 only. Rs. 248000.00 only.
7	Date of Opening Tender	Date: 21.04.2026 Time: 05:00 PM
8	Name & Address of Office Inviting tender	Executive Engineer, Minor Irrigation Division, Sahibganj
a	Contact No. of Procurement Officer	Mob- 9693906454 Email Id- eesahibganj@gmail.com
b	Help line Number. of e-Procurement Cell	Mob- 9693906454

➤ Only e-Tender will be accepted.
➤ Published Estimated cost may be Increase or Decrease.
➤ Further details can be seen on website http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Executive Engineer, Minor Irrigation Division, Sahibganj

PR 376465 Minor Irrigation(26-27)#D

परिशिष्ट-I

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER MINOR IRRIGATION DIVISION, GIRIDIH

Email id – midivisionmi10@gmail.com e-Procurement Notice

Short e-Tender Reference No. – 01/F2/2026-27/WRD/M.I.D/ GIRIDIH Date :- 02.04.2026

1	Name of Work	Construction of Series of Checkdam across Ganduba River at Vill Borapahari Under block Pirtnad Dist. – Giridih
2	Estimated Cost	1,45,52,519.00
3	Time of Completion	11 Month
4	Date of Publication of E-Tender on website	06.04.2026 10:00 AM
5	Last date/Time for submission of E-Tender BID's	18.04.2026 05:00 PM
6	Last date for online submission of E-Tender fee and EMD	18.04.2026
7	Date of opening Tender	20.04.2026
8	Name & Address of office Inviting tender	Office of the Executive Engineer Minor Irrigation Division, Giridih
a	Contact no. of e-Procurement officer	+91979835646
b	Helpline number of e-procurement cell	+917979969322

Note:- (1) Only e-Tenders will be accepted.
(2) Published Estimated Cost may be Increase or Decrease
Further Details can be seen on website http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Sd/- Executive Engineer Minor Irrigation Division, Giridih
PR 376593 Minor Irrigation(26-27)D

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER MINOR IRRIGATION DIVISION, GIRIDIH

e-Procurement Tender Notice Two Envelope System

Short Tender Reference No. :- WRD/M.I.DIV./ GIRIDIH/B.D./S.L.I-01/2026-27

Letter No. 295/M.I.Div.Giridih Dt:- 02.04.2026

1.	Name of the work	Construction of Chief Minister Solar Based Lift Irrigation Scheme at Murkhar (Simani) under Block-Jamua, District- Giridih.
2.	Estimated Cost (in Rs.)	Rs. 1,23,41,899.00
3.	Cost of Tender Document (in Rs.)	Rs. 10,000.00 only (non-refundable)
4.	Earnest Money Deposit (in Rs.)	Rs. 1,23,500.00 only
5.	Time of Completion	11 Months
6.	Mode of Submission of Tender	Online through www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in
7.	Date of Publication of Tender on website (http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in)	Date: 06.04.2026, 11:00 A.M.
8.	Last Date/Time for downloading of bidding documents and submission of Tender on Website	Date: 18.04.2026, 05:00 P.M.
9.	Submission of Tender Fee and EMD	Start Date: 06.04.2026, 11:00 A.M. Last Date: 18.04.2026, 05:00 P.M.
10.	Technical Bid Opening Date	Date: 20.04.2026, 05:00 P.M.
11.	Officer Inviting Bids	Executive Engineer, Minor Irrigation Division, Giridih.
12.	Contact No. of Procurement Officer email of Procurement Officer	Mob. No.- 9798355646 Email Id- midivisionmi10@gmail.com
13.	Help line No. of Procurement Cell	Mob. No.- 7979969322

➤ Note :- Estimated cost may increase or decrease.
➤ Work will be awarded to those bidders (specially MNRE approved channel partners/MNRE approved manufacturers/ MNRE approved PV system integrators/ A registered manufacturers/ Company/ Firm/ Corporation in India (including MSME of Jharkhand) of at least one of the major sub system namely pumps or PV System electronics (confirming to National/ International Standards)/ any other agencies having experience of installation and commissioning of such solar powered irrigation schemes). Empanelled Indigenous Manufacturers of 10 HP pumps (AC Surface water Pumps) in the department with all accessories for off-grid stand alone SPV water pumping systems can also take part in the bid for executing the whole work of the bid. However those bidders who have not yet registered in Water Resources Department can also submit their bid provided they will have to get themselves registered in Water Resources Department within two months from the date of allotment of work.
➤ Only e-Tender will be accepted.
➤

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 221 -GopiballavpurAssembly Constituency

Name of the candidate – Ajit Mahata

Sl.no.		
1.	Criminal antecedents	
i)	a.	Nature of the offences
		Offences alleged under Sections: 1. Section 121 of West Bengal Municipal Act, 1993 2. Section 121 of West Bengal Municipal Act, 1993 3. Section 121 of West Bengal Municipal Act, 1993 4. Section 23A of West BengalPanchayat Act, 1993 5. Section 121 of West Bengal Municipal Act, 1993
	b.	Case no.
		1. NGR 1057/2019 2. NGR 1099/2019 3. NGR 1061/2019 4. NGR 1052/2019 5. NGR 1059/2019
	c.	Name of the Court
		1. Learned C.J.M,Jhargram 2. Learned C.J.M, Jhargram 3. Learned C.J.M, Jhargram 4. Learned C.J.M, Jhargram 5. Learned C.J.M, Jhargram
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)
		1. Yes on 14/11/2025 2. Yes on7/2/2026 3. Yes on14/11/2025 4. Yes on11/9/2025 5. Yes on14/11/2025
	e.	Date of conviction, if any
		N/A
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any
		N/A
	g.	Any other information required to be given
		N/A
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere "winnability" at the polls (not more than 100 words)	
	The candidate is a political figure associated with the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) in West Bengal. He completed his studies from BA from JK College, Purulia in 1974, University of Burdwan. He has been active in local organisational work within the party and is known for his role in constituency-level political mobilisation and community outreach. His activities largely centre around grassroots engagement, party strengthening, and participation in AITC's regional political programmes. His public profile reflects the broader dynamics of local politics in the state, with his political presence shaped by ongoing organisational and electoral developments.	
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)	
	This individual has a long-standing association with party activities, and consistent participation in regional programmes. His established presence, familiarity with local political dynamics, and proven ability to strengthen party networks made him a more suitable choice for effective representation and electoral preparedness. He is a veteran politician in the state, commanding immense respect of civil society, especially amongst the marginalised communities in the backward districts of Jhargram and Purulia.	

(2) Name of the Constituency – 221 -GOPIBALLAVPUR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Ajit Mahata

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien

Member, National Working Committee

All India Trinamool Congress

Strong 7.4 magnitude quake shakes Indonesia; 1 killed

MANADO: An undersea earthquake of 7.4 magnitude toppled buildings in parts of northern Indonesia, sent people fleeing from their homes, killed at least one person and generated a small tsunami Thursday.

Waves up to 75 cm (30 inches) above normal tides were recorded at several monitoring stations about a half-hour after the earthquake, which was centred in the Molucca Sea.7 and the Philippine Institute of Volcanology and Seismology said there was no destructive threat to the country, which is north of the quake's epicentre.

Strong shaking lasting 10 to 20 seconds was felt in Bitung in North Sulawesi province as well as in Ternate city in neighbouring North Maluku province, according to Indonesia's Disaster Management Agency. Initial assessments showed light to severe damage in parts of Ternate, including a church and two houses. In Bitung, damage assessments were still underway, the agency said.

Indonesia's Search and Rescue Agency reported a 70-year-old woman died in a building collapse in North Sulawesi's



Onlookers gather as police officers inspect a damaged building following an earthquake in Manado on Thursday AP/PTI

Highlights

- » Waves up to 75 cm above normal tides were recorded at several monitoring stations about a half-hour after the earthquake
- » Indonesia's meteorological agency lifted its tsunami warning hours after the quake

Manado city and another resident was injured. At least three injured people were hospitalised in Ternate. Videos released by the rescue agency showed

damaged structures and flattened houses, while television stations broadcast scenes of people rushing outside and gathering in streets to avoid

the risk of collapsing buildings. Nearly 50 aftershocks were felt in nearby areas.

"We had just woken up and suddenly the earthquake hit... we all ran out of the house," Bitung resident Marten Mandagi said. "The shaking was very strong." Indonesia, a vast archipelago of more than 280 million people, sits on major seismic faults and is frequently hit by earthquakes and volcanic eruptions. AGENCIES

Prez Trump says will sign order to resume pay for Homeland Security

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said Thursday he will soon sign an order to pay all Department of Homeland Security employees who have gone without paychecks during the partial government shutdown that has reached 48 days.

He announced the unilateral move in a social media post, blaming Democrats for the impasse while thanking Republican leaders for their work this week in trying to end the standoff.

The Republican president used a similar maneuver to resume pay for the Transportation Security Administration after many employees had called out from work, resulting in long delays at airport security lines for travellers.

Trump's latest intervention is expected to apply to other non-law enforcement employees at the department, including the Federal Emergency Management Agency and the US Coast Guard and support staff.

Trump said their families "have suffered far too long." "Nevertheless, help is on



US President Donald Trump speaks about the Iran war from the Cross Hall of the White House on Wednesday in Washington AP/PTI

“THERE WAS NO LEGISLATIVE RESOLUTION ON THURSDAY AFTER BOTH CHAMBERS MET FOR JUST A FEW MINUTES IN PRO FORMA SESSIONS”

the way for our Brave and Patriotic Public Servants who have continued to work hard, and do their part to protect and defend our Country,”

Trump said. The DHS funding lapse had seemed likely to stretch into next week as the House is contemplating passing a Senate plan it had previously rejected to fund the bulk of the agency, but not its immigration enforcement operations.

There was no legislative resolution Thursday after both chambers met for just a few minutes in pro forma sessions. AGENCIES

Nonetheless, the Republican leadership and Trump had coalesced around a plan to fully fund DHS as part of a two-step process.

‘Russia plans to send 2nd oil tanker to Cuba’

MOSCOW: Russia plans to send a second oil tanker to Cuba, the country's Energy Minister Sergei Tsivilyov said on Thursday.

The announcement comes just two days after sanctioned Russian tanker Anatoly Kolodkin docked at the Cuban port of Matanzas laden with 730,000 barrels of oil, marking the first time in three months that an oil tanker reached the island.

"Cuba is in a total blockade, it's been cut off. Whose shipment of oil made it?"

A Russian vessel broke through the blockade. A second one is being loaded right now, we will not leave Cubans alone in trouble," the minister said. Cuba produces barely 40 per cent of its required fuel and relies on imports to sustain its energy grid. Experts say the anticipated shipment could produce about 180,000 barrels of diesel, enough to feed Cuba's daily demand for nine or 10 days. AGENCIES

NASA astronauts start next stage of Moon mission after historic launch in decades

It is the humanity's first lunar voyage in more than half a century

CAPE CANAVERAL: Four astronauts embarked on a high-stakes flight around the moon Wednesday, humanity's first lunar voyage in more than half a century and the thrilling lead-off in NASA's push toward a landing in two years.

Carrying three Americans and one Canadian, the 32-story rocket rose from NASA's Kennedy Space Centre where tens of thousands gathered to witness the dawn of this new era.

Crowds also jammed the surrounding roads and beaches, reminiscent of the Apollo moonshots in the 1960s and '70s. It is NASA's biggest step yet toward establishing a permanent lunar presence.

"On this historic mission, you take with you the heart of this Artemis team, the daring spirit of the American people and our partners across the globe, and the hopes and dreams of a new generation," launch director Charlie Blackwell-Thompson told the crew right before liftoff. "Good luck, Godspeed Artemis II. Let's go."

Artemis II set sail from the same Florida launch site that sent Apollo's explorers to the moon so long ago.

The handful still alive cheered this next generation's grand adventure as the Space Launch System rocket thundered into the early evening sky, a nearly full moon beck-



People gather as NASA's Space Launch System (SLS) rocket being carried the Orion spacecraft lifts off on the Artemis II mission from the Kennedy Space Center, in Cape Canaveral PTI

oning some 248,000 miles (400,000 km) away.

Five minutes into the flight, Commander Reid Wiseman saw the team's target: "We have a beautiful moonrise, we're headed right at it," he said from the capsule.

On board with him are pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Canada's Jeremy Hansen. It is the most diverse lunar crew ever with the first woman, person of colour and non-US citizen riding in NASA's new Orion capsule.

Artemis II set sail from the same Florida launch site that sent Apollo's explorers to the moon so long ago

"NASA is back in the business of sending astronauts to the moon," NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman told reporters following liftoff, calling the half-century hiatus a brief

intermission. Tensions were high earlier in the day as hydrogen fuel started flowing into the rocket. Dangerous hydrogen leaks erupted during a countdown test earlier this year, forcing a lengthy flight delay.

To NASA's relief, no significant hydrogen leaks occurred. The launch team loaded more than 700,000 gallons of fuel (2.6 million litres) into the 32-story Space Launch System rocket on the pad, a smooth operation that set the stage for the Artemis II crew to board. AGENCIES

India looking at preferential market access in US: Goyal

Commerce & Industry Minister said that India’s trade pact with US is ‘best’ compared to its competitor nations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said India is looking at preferential market access for its products in the US and asserted that the country’s relations with America are “very robust” with a deep strategic partnership across technology, defence, trade and investment.

He said that India’s trade pact with the US is “best” as compared to its competitor countries.

“Our relations are very robust. We have a deep strategic partnership on several aspects, on technology, on defence, on trade and on investments, and our approach is that India should get preferential market access,” Goyal told reporters here.

The country, he said, is sitting on a “very sweet spot” in promoting trade with the US. “Being the world’s fastest growing economy, India holds huge promise for investors who will continue to look at the India opportunity in greater numbers and greater value in the future,” he added.

On March 27, the minister held a meeting with the US Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer in Yaounde,



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

‘Being the world’s fastest growing economy, India holds huge promise for investors who will continue to look at the India opportunity in greater numbers and greater value in the future’

Cameroon and discussed the next steps in the India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations.

The two met on the sidelines of the 14th ministerial conference (MC14) of the World Trade Organisation.

In February, the two countries announced that they had finalised a framework for the first phase of the bilateral trade

agreement. It has not yet been signed.

India and the US announced a trade deal on February 2. A joint statement for the same was released on February 7.

However, the tariff architecture in the US has changed following its Supreme Court

Highlights

- » The country, he said, is sitting on a ‘very sweet spot’ in promoting trade with the US
- » India and the US announced a trade deal on February 2. A joint statement for the same was released on February 7
- » According to the framework, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent
- » However, the tariff architecture in the US has changed following its Supreme Court ruling against President Trump’s sweeping tariffs

ruling against President Donald Trump’s sweeping tariffs. After that, the US President imposed 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days from February 24.

In view of these changes, a meeting of the chief negotiators of India and the US has been postponed. They were scheduled to meet in February to finalise the legal text of the pact.

No windfall tax on diesel, ATF exports from Reliance SEZ refinery: Official

‘As per judicial pronouncements on this issue, the special additional excise duty and additional excise duty are not applicable on SEZ refineries’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The reimposed windfall export taxes on diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) will not apply to Reliance Industries Ltd’s SEZ refinery due to judicial rulings, a senior official said on Thursday.

Effective March 26, the government revised fuel levies, reintroducing export duties of Rs 21.50 per litre on diesel and Rs 29.50 per litre on ATF, while keeping petrol exports exempt. The move coincided with a Rs 10 per litre cut in excise duty on petrol and diesel.

Initially, it was not clear if exports from Reliance’s special economic zone (SEZ) refinery - one of the largest contributors to India’s refined product exports - would retain exemptions similar to those under the 2022 windfall tax regime.

“As per judicial pronouncements on this issue, the special additional excise duty and additional excise duty are not applicable on SEZ refineries,” Jainendra Singh Kandhari, Joint Secretary in the Tax Research Unit (TRU-1) of the Department of Revenue, said at a media briefing.

The government reinstated the windfall export tax amid disruptions to global energy supplies caused by the Middle East conflict. The levy, first introduced in July 2022 follow-



The government reinstated the windfall export tax amid disruptions to global energy supplies caused by the Middle East conflict

ing Russia’s invasion of Ukraine and withdrawn in December 2024, has been reimposed in the form of a special additional excise duty (SAED) to encourage refiners to prioritise domestic sales over exports.

Reliance owns and operates two refineries at Jamnagar in Gujarat - a 33 million tonnes (MT) per year unit catering to the domestic market and a 35.2 million tonnes only-for-exports SEZ unit. The export tax will be reviewed fortnightly — as was the practice previously — to align the duty with prevailing rates. According to a Citi Research report, the export taxes are equivalent to \$36 per

barrel on diesel and \$50 per barrel on jet fuel.

“In FY25, 75 per cent of Reliance’s diesel production and 35 per cent of its jet fuel production were from its SEZ refinery, which we believe, based on 2022 precedent, could be exempt from this tax.

“If we therefore assume the export tax is applicable only on the non-SEZ volumes, the impact should be largely offset by still-elevated diesel/jet fuel cracks vs pre-conflict levels,” it had said in the report last week.

The government, on March 26, announced the first material reduction in domestic petroleum excise duty since April

Key Points

- » Reliance owns and operates two refineries at Jamnagar in Gujarat - a 33 MT per year unit catering to the domestic market and a 35.2 MT only-for-exports SEZ unit
- » Export tax will be reviewed fortnightly, as was the practice previously, to align duty with prevailing rates
- » The export taxes are equivalent to \$36 per barrel on diesel & \$50 per barrel on jet fuel

2022, offering relief to oil marketing companies (OMCs) that had been incurring huge losses after being unable to raise retail prices of petrol and diesel despite a sharp surge in crude oil costs.

In a separate note, Jefferies said the reimposed export duty broadly caps diesel/ATF spreads at \$20 per barrel for standalone refiners like Reliance. “This is similar to the level of margin caps introduced during the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022. However, this time the movement in crude premiums and freight rates has been very stiff, making capturing spreads challenging for global refiners.”

Bharti Airtel becomes 2nd-largest mobile operator in world



NEW DELHI: Bharti Airtel has become world’s second largest telecom operator with 650 million subscribers, the company said on Thursday citing GSMA data.

According to GSMA Intelligence, Bharti Airtel is ranked second globally by mobile customer base, with operations spread across India and Africa, the company said in a statement.

“...we will strive to raise the bar on innovation, reliability, and experience so that every customer interaction is an opportunity to earn trust and deliver value connection,” Gopal Vittal, Executive Vice Chairman, Bharti Airtel, said. A spokesperson said that data is based on numbers available till March 31. Airtel said it has over 368 million mobile customers in India and over 179 million customers across 14 countries. “Beyond its regional hubs, Airtel is bridging the digital divide through strategic partnership with Eutelsat OneWeb and SpaceX, utilizing a constellation of Low Earth Orbit (LEO) satellites to deliver high-speed, low-latency broadband to the most remote maritime, aviation, and rural areas,” the statement said. PTI

India’s defence exports rise to ₹38,424 cr in FY26

NEW DELHI: India’s annual defence exports touched an all-time high of Rs 38,424 crore in the financial year 2025-26, marking more than 62 per cent growth over the previous fiscal year, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Thursday.

The “big jump” in the defence exports reflected the growing “global trust” in India’s indigenous defence capabilities, Singh said in a social media post, adding that the country is “scripting an impressive defence exports success story”.

“India defence exports have touched a new all-time high with a record Rs 38,424 crore in FY 2025-26. It marks a robust 62.66 per cent growth over the previous fiscal,” the defence minister said.

“This big jump of Rs 14,802 crore in defence exports reflects the growing global trust in India’s indigenous capabilities and advanced manufacturing



India’s defence exports were Rs 23,622 cr in FY25 and Rs 21,083 cr in FY24

strength,” he said.

With DPSUs (defence public sector undertakings) contributing 54.84 per cent and private industry 45.16 per cent, this milestone showcases the power of a collaborative and self-reliant defence ecosystem, he said.

India’s defence exports were

Rs 23,622 crore in 2024-25 and Rs 21,083 crore in 2023-24.

The defence ministry described defence exports in 2025-26 as a “landmark milestone”.

“This accomplishment of the Indian defence industry is in line with the Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision to position India among the world’s top defence exporters,” it said.

“In terms of value of contribution, the private sector accounted for Rs 17,353 crore worth of defence exports, while DPSUs contributed Rs 21,071 crore. Their respective figures in the previous financial year stood at Rs 15,233 crore and Rs 8,389 crore,” it said.

This record high figure indicates an increase by around three times in the last five years, it said. The ministry said the “sharp rise” highlights the increasing global acceptance of Indian made defence products and the sector’s growing

integration into the international supply chains.

“Apart from being a successful global partner for systems/sub-systems, India is exporting defence equipment to more than 80 countries as of FY 2025-26. The number of exporters underwent a surge to 145 from 128, a 13.3 per cent rise from the previous fiscal,” it said.

The ministry said the government’s “continuous endeavours towards ease of doing business and facilitation of defence exporters have paved the way for a performance oriented and globally competitive defence industry”.

“To support defence exporters in this growth trajectory, the Department of Defence Production has streamlined defence export regulatory processes with a revamped online portal and simplified standard operation procedure for authorisations,” it said. PTI

Union govt liabilities rose due to rise in public debt in FY25: CAG

NEW DELHI: The Union government’s overall liabilities rose in FY25, driven primarily by higher public debt, the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) said in a report tabled in Parliament on Thursday. Internal and external debt grew by 8.35 per cent and 9.83 per cent, respectively against FY24. Internal debt stood at Rs 1,59,25,949 crore at the end of FY25, with market borrowings accounting for nearly 70 per cent of the total.

Capital expenditure as a share of GDP declined marginally to 2.70 per cent in FY25 from 2.78 per cent in FY24. Debt repayment remained the largest expenditure head,

accounting for 62.57 per cent of total outgo from the Consolidated Fund of India.

The report highlighted an improvement in fiscal indicators. Revenue deficit fell 26.24 per cent year-on-year to 1.78 per cent of GDP, while fiscal deficit declined 8.27 per cent to 4.62 per cent, reflecting better control over spending and steady revenue growth.

However, the auditor flagged several accounting irregularities. Discrepancies were found in the Central Government Employees Group Insurance Scheme, including incorrect booking of transactions and variations between records maintained by different offices.

The CAG also noted misclassification of Rs 12,754.47 crore, including Rs 4,011.91 crore in receipts and Rs 8,742.56 crore in expenditure, largely due to incorrect booking under object heads. Instances of double accounting related to the Ministry of Railways were also observed. Further, supplementary provisions under 16 grants were found unnecessary as final expenditure re-mained below initial allocations.

Injudicious re-appropriations exceeding Rs 10 crore were also identified across multiple grants, leading to avoidable excess expenditure in some cases and highlighting gaps in budgetary management. AGENCIES

Discoms’ legacy dues reduce to ₹3,300 crore from ₹1.39 lakh crore in 4 years: Power Min

NEW DELHI: Outstanding legacy dues of power distribution companies (discoms) have sharply declined to about Rs 3,300 crore in March 2026 from Rs 1.39 lakh crore in June 2022, Parliament was informed on Thursday.

The reduction follows the implementation of the Electricity (Late Payment Surcharge and Related Matters) Rules, 2022, which mandated rescheduling of past dues into EMLs, Minister of State for Power Shripad Naik said. Under the rules, all dues owed to generating companies, traders and transmission utilities up to June 3, 2022 were classified as legacy arrears. These have since been steadily cleared,



bringing total outstanding legacy dues down to Rs 3,330 crore as of March 27, 2026.

The framework also ensured timely payment of current dues, with discoms adhering to payment time-lines to avoid regulatory action. Data from the PRAAPTI portal shows current dues at Rs 13,594 crore,

Reduction follows implementation of Electricity (Late Payment Surcharge & Related Matters) Rules, 2022

taking total outstanding dues, including legacy liabilities, to Rs 16,894 crore.

The government attributed earlier payment delays to factors such as regulatory disallowances, the gap between average cost of supply and revenue realised (ACS-ARR), and delays in subsidy payments and

government department dues by states. The minister highlighted that the Ujwal DISCOM Assurance Yojana (UDAY), launched in 2015, aimed at financial and operational turnaround of discoms, saw participation from 27 states and five Union Territories.

Additionally, the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS), launched in 2021, has sanctioned works worth Rs 2.83 lakh crore for loss reduction and smart metering. Fund release under RDSS is linked to improvements in operational and financial performance, helping enforce financial discipline while reducing technical and commercial losses. AGENCIES

Govt directive to offer 60% flight seats free of charge put on hold

MUMBAI: The government on Thursday “put in abeyance” its earlier direction to airlines to offer at least 60 per cent of seats in a flight without levying any additional charge from April 20, according to sources.

On March 18, the civil aviation ministry announced that directions have been issued to the DGCA to direct airlines to allocate a minimum of 60 per cent of seats for selection on any flight free of any additional charges to ensure fair access for passengers.

“The matter has been reviewed in light of representations received from the



Federation of Indian Airlines and Akasa Air, highlighting operational and commercial implications of the above provision, including its potential impact on fare structures and consistency with the prevailing deregulated tariff regime.

“In view of the above, and

pending a comprehensive examination of the issue, it has been decided that the provision relating to offering at least 60 per cent of seats free of charge shall be kept in abeyance till further orders,” Civil Aviation Ministry said in a communication to the DGCA.

At present, 20 per cent of the seats can be booked free of charge, while the rest are paid.

Generally, airlines charge Rs 200 to Rs 2,100 for choos- ing seats, depending on various factors, including front rows and extra leg room, a travel industry executive had said last week. PTI

NEW DELHI: The government has introduced a series of measures to support exporters affected by the ongoing Gulf conflict, a key market for Indian goods worth about \$57 billion in exports in 2024-25, a senior official said on Thursday.

At an inter-ministerial briefing, Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) Lav Aggarwal said the commerce ministry is working with insurers and banks to address rising war risk insurance premiums and trade finance challenges.

India’s bilateral trade with the Gulf region stood at \$178

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘Commerce ministry is working with insurers & banks on rising war risk insurance premiums & trade finance issues’
- » India had a bilateral trade of \$178 bn in FY25 (\$56.87 billion exports & \$121.67 bn imports) with Gulf region
- » For gems and jewellery, he said, the Gulf Cooperation Council is both a major export market and sourcing hub

billion in 2024-25, including \$56.87 billion in exports and \$121.67 billion in imports.

Key sectors under stress include petroleum products, chemicals, engineering goods, rice, phar-maceuticals, and gems and jewellery.

Aggarwal noted that higher freight costs, vessel rerouting and war-risk surcharges have disrupted shipments, especially for perishable goods like fruits and vegetables. Payment channels and credit cycles, particularly in the agri sector, are also

facing strain.

The Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) remains a critical market and sourcing hub for gems and jewellery. However, gold jewellery exports and sourcing of gold bars and rough diamonds have been impacted.

LPG supply disruptions have also affected manufacturing clusters involved in metal processing and gemstone polishing.

Engineering exporters are grappling with higher logistics costs and restricted port access, while MSMEs face shortages of raw materials, including key pharmaceutical inputs.

Longer shipping routes to the US and Europe have further increased transit time and costs.

To mitigate the impact, the government set up an inter-ministerial group on March 2 to assess and co-ordinate the response.

The group has held 20 meetings so far, with a dedicated sub-group focusing on facilitating movement of perishable cargo.

“The group continues to monitor the evolving situation and ensure coordinated action to support trade,” Aggarwal said. AGENCIES

Bourses stage stunning comeback on value buying & rupee rebound

At the end of the session, the rupee was quoted at 93.18 against the dollar, higher by 152 paise, or 1.6%, from its previous closing level

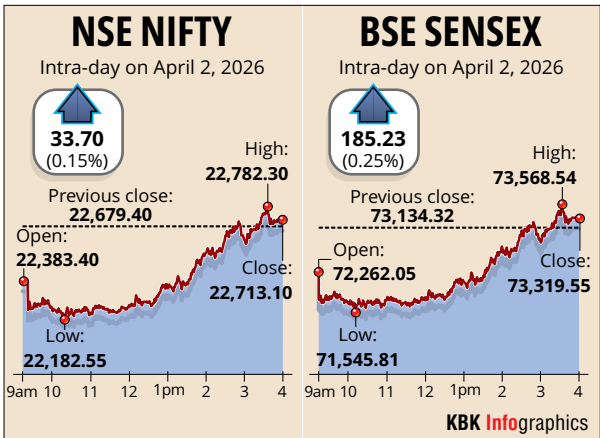
OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Staging a spirited recovery, stock markets pared early losses to close higher on Thursday, with the benchmark Sensex rising by 185 points and the broader Nifty settling above 22,700 on strong value buying in IT and banking shares and a sharp rebound in the rupee.

Rebounding more than 2,000 points from the day's low, the 30-share BSE Sensex finally settled higher by 185.23 points, or 0.25 per cent, at 73,319.55. The index opened lower and tanked further by 1,588 points to hit a day's low of 71,545.81 in the first half of the session.

The 50-share NSE Nifty followed a similar trajectory and closed above 22,700 at 22,713.10, up by 33.70 points, or 0.15 per cent. The index fell 496.85 points, or 2.19 per cent, in early trade before recovering to hit a high of 22,782.30.

A sharp rebound in the rupee after the Reserve Bank stepped in with a slew of measures to restrict banks from onshore forward markets also helped improve investor sentiment. The rupee rebounded by 188 paise to hit the 92 level against the US dollar briefly in the day trade before settling over 150 paise higher.



A sharp rebound in the rupee after the Reserve Bank stepped in with a slew of measures to restrict banks from onshore forward markets also helped improve investor sentiment

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.62 and registered a sharp single-day surge of 188 paise to touch an intra-day high of 92.82 against the greenback.

At the end of the session, the rupee was quoted at 93.18 against the dollar, higher by 152 paise, or 1.6 per cent, from its previous closing level.

Bargain hunting in IT stocks

supported the recovery, with HCL Technologies and Tech Mahindra ending nearly 3 per cent higher.

Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, HDFC Bank, Bajaj Finance, Maruti Suzuki India, Titan, Axis Bank, Bharat Electronics Ltd, Kotak Mahindra Bank and ITC were the major gainers among Sensex shares.

On the other hand, Asian

Highlights

» A total of 2,649 stocks advanced, while 1,589 declined and 149 remain unchanged on the BSE

» BSE SmallCap Select Index slipped 0.36%, while MidCap Select Index fell by 0.10%

» Among the sectoral indices, Focussed IT gained most by 2.76%, followed by IT (2.42%), Realty (1.19%), Top 10 Banks (0.46%), Pvt Banks Index (0.40%), Metal & Bankex by 0.35% each, FMCG (0.27%), & Financial Services (0.24 per cent)

Paints, Eternal, Sun Pharmaceuticals, NTPC, Reliance Industries, PowerGrid, Mahindra & Mahindra, UltraTech Cement, Adani Ports, Bajaj Finserv and Tata Steel were the only laggards.

US President Donald Trump, in his first national address since the Iran war began, said that the US will continue to hit Iran very hard.

The United States will "finish the job" in Iran soon as "core strategic objectives are nearing completion" and military operations could wrap up soon, Trump said in his Wednesday night speech.

Crude oil spiked more than 7 per cent after Trump's speech. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded \$7.28 per barrel at \$108.52 per barrel.

A total of 2,649 stocks advanced, while 1,589 declined and 149 remain unchanged on the BSE. BSE SmallCap Select Index slipped 0.36 per cent, while MidCap Select Index went lower by 0.10 per cent.

Among the sectoral indices, Focussed IT gained the most by 2.76 per cent, followed by IT (2.42 per cent), Realty (1.19 per cent), Top 10 Banks (0.46 per cent), Private Banks Index (0.40 per cent), Metal and Bankex by 0.35 per cent each, FMCG (0.27 per cent), and Financial Services (0.24 per cent). MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt, Oil & Gas, Consumer Durables, Hospitals, Energy, Healthcare, were among the laggards.

FII's offloaded equities worth Rs 8,331.15 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 7,171.80 crore.

India's mfg sector growth slips to four-year low in March: PMI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector growth eased to a four-year low in March as cost pressures, fierce competition, heightened market uncertainty and the war in the Middle East led to softer increases in new orders and output, a monthly report said on Thursday.

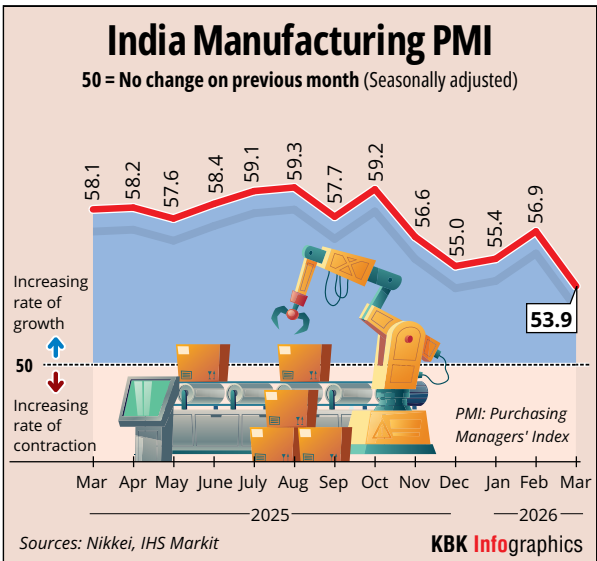
The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) fell from 56.9 in February to 53.9 in March, indicating the weakest improvement in overall business conditions in close to four years.

In the PMI parlance, a print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction.

"India's manufacturing PMI eased to 53.9 in March from 56.9 in February, marking its lowest level since June 2022. Disruptions linked to the conflict in the Middle East are reverberating through the global economy and weighing on Indian manufacturers," said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC.

The two largest sub-components of the PMI, new orders and output, rose at the slowest rates since mid-2022, the survey said, adding that growth was curbed by challenging market conditions, cost pressures and the war in the Middle East.

"Output and new orders slowed noticeably, signalling softer demand and greater uncertainty. Meanwhile, input costs rose sharply across a broad range of items, including alu-



'Disruptions linked to the conflict in the Middle East are reverberating through the global economy and weighing on Indian manufacturers'

minium, chemicals and fuels. For now, firms appear to be absorbing much of the increase, keeping output prices relatively contained," Bhandari said.

Firms faced an intensification of cost pressures, the steepest since August 2022. But, there was a slower increase in output charges. The rate of output price inflation receded to a two-year low, curbed by customer-

retention efforts and attempts to secure new clients at some firms, the survey said.

"March data saw input prices increase to the greatest extent in over three-and-a-half years. Aluminium, chemicals, fuel, jute, leather, fabric, oil, rubber and steel were some of the items reported to be up in price," Bhandari said.

Indian manufacturers registered the strongest expansion in external sales since last September, with gains noted from clients in Australia, Brazil, Canada, mainland China, Europe, Japan, the Middle East, Turkey and Vietnam. The survey further noted that Indian manufacturers raised employment to the greatest extent in seven months and became more optimistic towards the year-ahead outlook for production.

Silver tanks ₹9,000, gold falls ₹3,500 on weak global trends



NEW DELHI: Silver prices fell sharply by Rs 9,000 to Rs 2.37 lakh per kilogram in the national capital on Thursday, while gold declined Rs 3,500 to Rs 1.51 lakh per 10 grams amid a bearish sentiment in the domestic market.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal depreciated Rs 9,000, or 3.66 per cent, to Rs 2,37,000 (inclusive of all taxes) from Thursday's closing level of Rs 2,46,000 per kg.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity also declined Rs 3,500, or 2.26 per cent, to Rs 1,51,500 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes). In the international market, spot silver plummeted by \$5.49, or 7.32 per cent, to \$69.57 per ounce, while gold declined \$166.79, or 3.51 per cent, to \$4,591.52 per ounce.

Spot gold ended the sharp surge of three sessions on Thursday as crude oil has surged yet again after US President Trump's warning that Iran will be hit hard in the next two-three weeks, Praveen Singh, Head of commodities, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

UPI records 22.64 billion transactions in March: DFS

NEW DELHI: Transaction through the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) touched a record high of 22.64 billion in volume terms in March.

"UPI achieves 22.64 Bn transaction count in March'26! Thank you, India, for embracing digital payments and driving this revolution forward. Let's continue the journey of transforming the way we transact!" Department of Financial Services said in a post on X.

In volume terms, 22.64 billion transactions were carried during the month as compared to 18.3 billion a year ago, posting a growth of 24 per cent.

The UPI transaction in volume terms was 20.39 billion recorded in February. UPI combines the ease of use with strong security while following the RBI's two-factor authentication rule. This first

factor is the mobile number linked to the user's bank and the second is the UPI PIN, making transactions quick and safe from unauthorised access.

Today, UPI accounts for 85 per cent of all digital transactions in India. Its impact goes beyond national borders, powering nearly 50 per cent of global real-time digital payments.

UPI is already live in seven countries, including the UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, France, and Mauritius. Its entry in France is a milestone because it is UPI's first step in Europe. This allows Indians travelling or living there to pay seamlessly.

NPCI, an initiative of the RBI and the Indian Banks' Association, runs the UPI used for real-time payments between peers or at merchants' end while making purchases.

FPIs pull out ₹17,689 cr from FAR G-Secs amid crisis in Middle East

MUMBAI: Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have pulled out Rs 17,689 crore of their bets from Fully Accessible Route (FAR) government securities since the beginning of the conflict in Middle East, reflecting heightened risk aversion among the global investors and growing concerns over inflationary pressures linked to surging crude oil prices.

According to data from the Clearing Corporation of India, FPI investment in FAR government securities declined to Rs 3,13,318.661 crore as on April 1, from Rs 3,31,007.648 crore as on February 27, indicating a steady unwinding of positions by overseas investors in recent weeks.

Market participants said the outflows coincided with a sharp rise in domestic bond yields, particularly after geopolitical



'FPI investment in FAR G-Secs fell to Rs 3,13,318.661 cr as on April 1, from Rs 3,31,007.648 crore as on Feb 27'

tensions in the Middle East pushed global crude oil prices higher, raising inflation risks and tightening financial conditions across emerging markets.

During the same period, the yield on Indian government

bonds, especially the 10-year benchmark bond, rose by about 0.33 per cent.

On March 27, the yield on the benchmark paper settled above the 7 per cent mark, the highest-level seen in over 20 months, reflecting sustained selling pressure in the bond market across investor base.

Bond market experts noted that elevated yields reduce the attractiveness of existing bond holdings, leading foreign investors to trim exposure, especially in interest rate-sensitive segments such as government securities under the FAR route, which are fully accessible to overseas investors without investment caps.

A report by HDFC Bank indicated that the 10-year government bond yield is likely to trade in the range of 6.90-7.20 per cent in the near term.

Bharat ki Soch concludes 'Mantrana' series on mental health and social fragmentation

NEW DELHI: Amid rapid material progress and rising concerns over mental health and social fragmentation, Bharat ki Soch concluded its two-day flagship roundtable, the 'Mantrana' Series, on March 24-25.

Positioned as a platform for deep, deliberative dialogue, the series brought together scholars, cognitive scientists and practitioners to explore how Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS) can address modern psychological and leadership challenges. The discussions were organised under two themes—"The Inner Mechanics" and "The Outer Expression".

Chairman Anil Rajput, in



his inaugural address, stressed that true leadership begins with self-mastery. He noted that while modern life prioritises material gains, lasting peace lies in understanding and managing the mind. He described ancient Indian systems as "technolo-

gies of the mind" essential for navigating contemporary complexities. Experts offered multi-disciplinary insights into human consciousness and well-being. Dr Vinayachandra Banavathy highlighted the need for a disciplined intellect to regulate sen-

sory impulses, while Dr Sohoh Chakrabarty linked philosophical concepts like Maya with modern cognitive science. Dr Mala Kapadia outlined the four Purusharthas—Dharma, Artha, Kama and Moksha—as a balanced framework for sustainable growth.

Further discussions emphasised mental wellness through concepts such as the three gunas and the "witnessing principle". Prof Shivani Sharma underscored Karma Yoga as the basis of ethical leadership—acting with intensity while remaining detached from outcomes.

In closing, Rajput reiterated the need to align national progress with inner stability.

DVC reports strong performance in FY2025-26 across operations, finance

KOLKATA: Damodar Valley Corporation (DVC) reported a strong performance in FY 2025-26, marking gains across operations, finance, sustainability and community outreach.

The utility generated 40,103 million units (MU) of power, including 39,719 MU from thermal, 351 MU from hydel—exceeding targets—and a record 33.3 MU from solar, underlining its renewable push.

Several plants ranked among the top 10 performers (central sector) in PLF performance, while DVC commissioned India's first advanced Load Despatch Center (LDC) under ULDC Phase-III for real-time grid monitoring. It also completed full digitisation of

Revenue stood at Rs 24,629 crore with 99% collection efficiency and full capex utilisation

its transmission network and GIS mapping of assets.

Coal excavation touched a record 6 MMT at Tubed, Latehar, Jharkhand, alongside securing long-term fuel security with new coal mines (53 MMT capacity) namely Mahuagarhi, Dhulia North, Pirpainti Barahat, and Mandakini-B. DVC also supplied 714 MU of green energy across West Bengal and Jharkhand.

On the expansion front, DVC formed a joint venture with Coal India Limited for a 2x800 MW project in Jharkhand and progressed work on key thermal and floating solar projects.

Financially, revenue stood at Rs 24,629 crore with 99 per cent collection efficiency and full capital expenditure utilisation. The company achieved savings through coal optimisation and improved its credit rating.

DVC also advanced sustainability, achieving 104 per cent ash utilisation, and undertook afforestation and community initiatives, reinforcing its role in India's power sector growth.

NTPC Limited delivers strong operational performance in FY26

NEW DELHI: NTPC Limited, India's largest integrated power utility, highlighted its robust operational achievements for FY26, underscoring its pivotal role in strengthening India's energy security, and accelerating clean energy transition.

Continuing with its commitment to powering India's growth, NTPC generated 432.2 Billion Units of electricity during FY26, ensuring reliable and efficient supply of electricity.

Recording its highest-ever capacity addition in a single year, the company added 9,619 MW in FY26 that strengthens India's energy backbone

across conventional and renewable sources.

Further strengthening its RE footprints, NTPC added 5,488 MW of renewable capacity in FY26 across solar, wind, and Pumped Storage Projects (PSP), accelerating its journey towards building a greener and more sustainable energy future for India.

In FY26, NTPC achieved a coal production of 48.65 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT), registering a steady 6.22 per cent year-on-year (YoY) growth.

This performance continues to bolster India's energy

security through reliable and efficient mining operations.

Meanwhile, the company also recorded a strong growth in power trading, with 46.52 Billion Units (BU) traded in FY26, marking a robust 13 per cent YoY growth.

This expansion further strengthens power accessibility across the nation. During the period, NTPC achieved 105 per cent ash utilisation, utilising 109 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) of ash. This outstanding performance reinforces NTPC's leadership in sustainable practices and circular resource management.

GURUGRAM: India's real estate sector continued to attract strong institutional interest in Q1 2026, with investments rising 25 per cent year-on-year to \$1.6 billion, led by robust domestic participation despite global uncertainties.

Domestic inflows surged 57 per cent annually to \$1.2 billion, accounting for nearly three-fourths of total investments—well above the 20-50 per cent share seen over the past few years. Despite a quarter-on-quarter (Q-o-Q) moderation, overall inflows remained 64 per cent higher than the average first-quarter levels since 2020,

CLOSER LOOK

» Despite a Q-o-Q moderation, overall inflows remained 64% higher than first-quarter levels since 2020

» Foreign investments, however, declined 23 per cent Year-on-Year to \$0.4 billion

» At the city level, Delhi-NCR led with over \$0.4 billion in inflows, followed by Bengaluru at \$0.3 billion

highlighting sustained optimism across asset classes.

Foreign investments, however, declined 23 per cent YoY to \$0.4 billion, reflecting caution amid volatility in global trade and commodity markets. Analysts expect overseas

investors to adopt a wait-and-watch approach in the near term, though strong domestic demand is likely to cushion the impact. "Institutional investments remain resilient, supported by strong domestic demand. The current cau-

tion among global investors is likely to be temporary, given India's favourable demographics and consumption-driven economy," said Badal Yagnik.

At the city level, Delhi-NCR led with over \$0.4 billion in inflows, followed by Bengaluru at \$0.3 billion. Together, the two markets accounted for 46 per cent of total investments, driven largely by office transactions. Multi-city deals contributed nearly one-third of inflows, with hospitality and residential assets gaining traction across markets.

Office assets dominated with \$0.8 billion, accounting for half

of total investments and nearly doubling year-on-year. Domestic investors contributed over 90 per cent of these inflows, reflecting strong confidence in high-quality, income-generating office assets. Residential investments stood at \$0.3 billion, up 7 per cent annually.

Meanwhile, hospitality, retail and alternative segments together accounted for over 20 per cent of total in-flows, with foreign capital contributing around 70 per cent, indicating diversification into emerging asset classes, said Vimal Nadar, National Director & Head of Research, Colliers India.

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 214– Bhagabanpur Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate – Manab Kumar Parua

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences Alleged Under: 1. Sections 34/307/323/325/341/342/379 of IPC, 1860. 2. Sections 34/323/325/341/ 354B/427/ 447of IPC, 1860. 3. Sections 147/148/149/325/341/354/37 9/427/436/506 of IPC, 1860 and Section 9 of the M.P.O Act. 4. Sections 147/148/149/302/326/342of IPC, 1860 and Section 9B of Explosives Act1884.
	b.	Case no.	1. G.RCase No. 340/2023 2. G.R Case No. 4310/2022 3. Sessions Case No. 309/2023 4. Sessions Case No. 322/2023
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned ACJM, Contai, Purba Medinipur) 2. Learned ACJM, Contai, Purba (Medinipur) 3. Learned Addl. District and Session Judge Contai, Purba (Medinipur) 4. Learned Addl. District and Session Judge, Contai, Purba (Medinipur)
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No 4. Yes
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	N/A
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	N/A
	g.	Any other information required to be given	N/A
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		
	The candidate has been selected on the basis of his demonstrated public engagement, financial transparency, and integrity. He has disclosed all assets, liabilities,andpendingcasesinaccordance with law, reflecting accountability and honesty. He is a dedicated social worker who has consistently worked towards the development and welfare of society, especially at the grassroots level. His continuous involvement in community upliftment and public service reflects his merit and suitability. The selection is therefore based on his commitment to social welfare, transparency, and ability to represent public interests, rather than mere electoral winnability.		
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		
	Same as above.		

(2) Name of the Constituency – 214 – BHAGABANPUR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Manab Kumar Parua

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien

Member, National Working Committee

All India Trinamool Congress

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 275 – Pandabeswar Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate – Narendranath Chakraborty

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences Alleged Under: 1. Sections 147/149/323/379 of IPC, 1860. 2. Sections 120B/323/341/379/506 of IPC, 1860. 3. Sections 34/335/341 of IPC, 1860. 4. Sections 323/325/379 of IPC, 1860. 5. Sections 147/148/149/379 of IPC, 1860. 6. Sections 147/323 of IPC, 1860.
	b.	Case no.	1. G.R No. 59 of 2013 2. G.R No. 614 of 2012 3. G.R No. 1416 of 2009 4. G.R No. 306 of 2008 5. G.R No. 306 of 2008 6. G.R No. 770 of 98
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned Judicial Magistrate 4 th Court, Durgapur 2. Learned Judicial Magistrate 4 th Court, Durgapur 3. Learned Judicial Magistrate 2 nd Court Durgapur 4. Learned Judicial Magistrate 2 nd Court Durgapur 5. Learned Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Durgapur 6. Learned Judicial Magistrate 2 nd Court Durgapur, Durgapur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No 4. No 5. No 6. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	N/A
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	N/A
	g.	Any other information required to be given	N/A
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		
	The candidate has been selected on the basis of his consistent commitment to public welfare and active engagement in social service. He is a dedicated social worker who has continuously worked towards the development and upliftment of society, demonstrating a strong sense of responsibility and service to the community. His selection is grounded in merit, integrity, and his proven efforts in contributing to social progress, rather than mere electoral considerations..		
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		
	Same As Above.		

(2) Name of the Constituency – 275 – PANDABESWAR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Narendranath Chakraborty

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien

National Working Committee Member

All India Trinamool Congress

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE

KKR slump continues as Klaasen guides SRH to 65-run victory

KOLKATA: Heinrich Klaasen's experience-driven half-century guided Sunrisers Hyderabad back to winning ways as they thrashed Kolkata Knight Riders by 65 runs in their IPL clash here on Thursday.

Blessing Muzarabani grabbed 4/41 but it was Klaasen's composed 52 off 35 balls that held Sunrisers Hyderabad's innings together as they posted a competitive 226/8 after KKR opted to bowl.

Chasing the daunting target, KKR never found momentum as they were bundled out for 161 and slumped to their second successive defeat, having lost their opening match to Mumbai Indians at the Wankhede. Boasting a batting-heavy lineup in Finn Allen, IPL's costliest overseas buy Cameron Green (Rs 25.20-crore), Rinku Singh and Sunil Narine, the target at the free-flowing Eden looked par.

It needed a partnership in the middle but there were clear signs of a lack of chemistry in the KKR line-up as they lasted just 16 overs.

That their mystery spinner Varun Chakravathy leaked 25 runs in one over and returned with 0/31 from two overs also hurt them. Narine (0/39) also returned wicketless from his four overs. For SRH, left-arm



Players exchange handshake after Sunrisers Hyderabad won the Indian Premier League match between Kolkata Knight Riders and Sunrisers Hyderabad, at Eden Gardens in Kolkata on Thursday

pacer Jaydev Nadkat took 3/21 from three overs that included the wicket of Rahane, while Ehsan Malinga (2/14 in two overs) and Nitish Kumar Reddy (2/17 in two overs) were also effective.

KKR's veteran skipper Ajinkya Rahane's painful eight off 10 balls once again raised questions over the team's bold leadership call, while partnerships failed to materialise.

Youngster Angkrish Raghuvanshi showed promised with a breezy 52 (29 balls; 6x4, 2x6) but there was no support from

the other end. Fresh from his 100 not out in the T20 World Cup semifinal against South Africa a month ago on the same wicket, Kiwi opener Finn Allen showed early sparks in a seven-ball 28 (4x4, 2x6).

But once he fell to Harsh Dubey giving a return catch, the innings unravelled quickly.

KKR's star recruit Green endured another failure, run out for two, following a chaotic mix-up with Raghuvanshi who played the shot. But Malinga stopped the ball with his foot

and Green was off the crease. Raghuvanshi started walking but review showed Green hasn't crossed so the Aussie had to depart.

The confusion did not end there. Raghuvanshi, who top-scored for KKR, was involved in yet another mix-up and was run out, summing up KKR's plight. Half the side was back in the pavilion soon after Anukul Roy's dismissal, leaving the chase in tatters. Vice-captain Rinku Singh offered brief resistance with a 35 off 25 balls, but his dismissal to Reddy ended

Highlights

» Blessing Muzarabani grabbed 4/41 but it was Klaasen's composed 52 off 35 balls that held Sunrisers Hyderabad's innings together as they posted a competitive 226/8 after KKR opted to bowl

» It needed a partnership in the middle but there were clear signs of a lack of chemistry in the KKR line-up as they lasted just 16 overs

any lingering hopes. Walking in after a dramatic middle-over slide from being 110/1 in eight overs to 118/4 in 9.2 overs, Klaasen rebuilt the innings with calm assurance, ensuring the run rate never dipped out of control.

Even as boundaries dried up, the seasoned South African smartly rotated strike and ran hard between the wickets, keeping SRH around the 11-run mark alongside Nitish Kumar Reddy (39; 24 balls) in a match-deciding 82 runs alliance off 53 balls.

AGENCIES

Are we Mossad agents in Iran, asks Nakamura

Slams FIDE's tough anti-cheating protocols at Candidates

NEW DELHI: American Grandmaster Hikaru Nakamura has slammed the International Chess Federation (FIDE) for its stringent anti-cheating measures at the ongoing Candidates Tournament in Cyprus, calling them "complete nonsense".

The world number two expressed his frustration when asked about the anti-cheating measures at the elite tournament to determine D Gukesh's challenger for the world championship later this year.

He said the scanners and machines around the playing area have made the players feel like Mossad (Israeli intelligence) agents operating inside Iran. "My general view about the whole topic of delay, cheating over the board, all that stuff is that I frankly think it's nonsense. I do think it really is, considering the amount of machines they have to scan the players in the room," Nakamura said on his YouTube channel in conversation with Norwegian GM Jon Ludvig Hammer and Luxembourg's WIM Fiona Steil-Antoni.

Nakamura, one of the eight players competing in the Open section of the Candidates, added that FIDE should "get real", saying it was impossible to cheat with an elite field and so many arbiters in the playing hall.

"I think it's all complete



American Grandmaster Hikaru Nakamura

The world number two expressed his frustration when asked about the anti-cheating measures at the elite tournament

nonsense. That not to say I have a problem with that per se but I just think that the fears that some players have expressed. I'm just going to be honest...they scan us before the games they scan us after the game," he said. "They have the metal detectors, they have the separate scanners, I mean... I feel like what are we all? Mossad agents inside Iran or something. Come on, we are chess players, let's be real, seriously, let's be real," said Nakamura.

AGENCIES

Batting at number 4 gave me confidence: Rizvi

LUCKNOW: Young Delhi Capitals batter Sameer Rizvi grabbed the the opportunity to bat at number four with both hands and said his only focus now is to maintain the consistency going forward in the IPL.

Rizvi gave ample display of his talent, coming in as an 'Impact Player' to help Delhi Capitals get past Lucknow Super Giants by six wickets after a shaky start here on Wednesday.

Chasing 142, DC were reduced to 26 for 4 within first five overs but Rizvi (70 not out off 47 balls), coming in for T Natarajan, conjured an unbroken 119-run stand for the fifth wicket with the seasoned Tristan Stubbs (39 not out off 32 balls) to chase down the target in just 17.1 overs.

Rizvi showed exemplary maturity during his knock and hit five fours and four sixes on a tricky track.

"Coaches told me before that you will play at No.4 position and we will back you. You just play your natural, positive game," said the 22-year-old Uttar Pradesh cricketer.

"Whenever I play for UP or in UPT20 league, I bat at no.4 and if you get to bat at the same position in IPL it gives a lot of confidence. It is a big opportunity for me and they (coaches) are also giving me freedom to play my natural game. So I just make my mindset to grab these opportunities."

AGENCIES

Salah's long goodbye: Egypt star begins farewell tour with Liverpool at Man City in FA Cup

Salah was left out of the Liverpool team for four straight games at the end of 2025 in what appeared to be a breakdown in his relationship with Slot & club

LIVERPOOL: Mohamed Salah's long goodbye to Liverpool begins on Saturday in the quarterfinals of the FA Cup, the competition which represents his best chance of a trophy in his final year at Anfield.

The Egypt winger announced last week that he will be leaving Liverpool at the end of the season after nine years at a club where he has

broken scoring records and established himself as one of the world's best players.

Salah potentially has 15 games left in the famous red shirt: Seven in the Premier League as well as three in the FA Cup and five in the Champions League, should Liverpool reach the final in both of those competitions.

That won't be easy.

In the Champions League, defending champion Paris Saint-Germain is up next in the two-leg quarterfinals and it's pretty much as tough in the FA Cup, with Liverpool handed an away match at Manchester City.

Salah, who has 255 goals in 435 appearances for Liverpool, missed the Reds' last game before the international



Mohamed Salah break — a 2-1 loss at Brighton in the league — with a

Takeaways

» Salah potentially has 15 games left in the famous red shirt

» Salah virtually has been an ever-present in the lineup, seemingly winning the Dutch coach round

muscle injury but has told manager Arne Slot he should be healthy enough to return this weekend.

"So, he will train with the team again tomorrow and if everything works well then he's available to be with us at City."

The 33-year-old Salah was left out of the Liverpool team for four straight games at the end of 2025 in what appeared to be a breakdown in his relationship with Slot and the club.

"That hunger never drops," Slot said of Salah. "It's the thing I find most special about him. So many good players around the world — he's definitely one of them in the last 10 years — and to show that hunger every three days, that professionalism, that commitment to the club and to the team, wanting to score again, always wanting to play ..."

AGENCIES

India gear up for Billie Jean King Cup, target another playoff berth

NEW DELHI: India have begun their preparations for the upcoming Billie Jean King Cup Asia/Oceania Group 1 tournament in the national capital, with captain Vishal Uppal expressing confidence in a balanced squad that blends experience and youth.

The team assembled in Delhi earlier this week to acclimatise to the conditions ahead of the April 7-11 tournament, with Uppal stressing the importance of early preparation.

"We've just got here to Delhi... and come the 7th of April, we'll be ready to come out and fight for India. We really hope the people of Delhi come out in large numbers and support 'Team India'," Uppal told PTI Videos.

Reflecting on last year's campaign, where India made the playoffs but fell short of advancing further, Uppal highlighted the need for collective

India's recent performances underline steady progress in women's tennis

effort. "Tennis is an individual sport, but here it has to be a team effort. This year, all of us have to play our role and give our heart and soul day in and day out," he added.

India's recent performances underline steady progress in women's tennis. The team has qualified for the World Group playoffs twice in the last six years after a 42-year drought before 2020. "Everyone wants to live in a penthouse, but you have to build the floors first. We are in the process of building women's tennis in India," Uppal explained, underlining the long-term vision.

AGENCIES

Mitchell Santner joins Mumbai Indians' squad

NEW DELHI: New Zealand T20I skipper Mitchell Santner on Thursday joined the Mumbai Indians squad here ahead of their Indian Premier League match against Delhi Capitals.

The five-time winners Mumbai Indians will take on the Capitals at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Saturday afternoon.

Santner and England all-rounder Will Jacks were the only two players left to join Mumbai Indians, who had convincingly won their season opener against Kolkata Knight Riders last Sunday in Mumbai.

The two overseas players, who had featured prominently for their respective teams in last month's T20 World Cup, had asked for an extended period before joining the MI squad.

MI head coach Mahela Jayawardene had confirmed giving these two players extended time off for personal reasons.

AGENCIES

India's woeful Shotgun WC campaign ends

TANGIER: Indian shooters' disappointing run showed no signs of abating, as both mixed team pairs turned in sub-par performances to finish way down in the standings, capping a forgettable outing at the ISSF Shotgun World Cup here on Thursday.

Extending India's run of underwhelming results in the men's and women's skeet and trap events, the mixed doubles pair of Olympian Prithviraj Tondaiman and Kirti Gupta could only muster an aggregate of 134, slumping to a disappointing 18th place in a 33-team field. Only the top four teams enter the finals.

Tondaiman scored 69 (24, 22, 23) in his three round of 25 each, totalling 75 while Gupta missed 10 clay targets to finish with 65 (22, 22, 21).

The other Indian pair, Olympians Kynan Chenai and Rajeshwari Kumari, also endured a below-par outing, combining for a modest 130 to finish 25th. Chenai shot 68



Representational Image

(25, 21, 22), while Rajeshwari managed 62 (18, 22, 22), in the season-opening World Cup -- an event whose scores carry significant weight for selection for the Asian Games in Japan later this year.

With the next Shotgun World Cup scheduled in Almaty, Kazakhstan, in May, India have already announced their squad, and notably, none of the shooters from the current event have been retained.

The national squad's dismal showing at the Tangier World Cup could prove costly, potentially knocking several shooters out of Asian Games contention.

AGENCIES

Japan thrash India 6-0 in AFC U20 Women's Asian Cup

PATHUM THANI: India suffered a 6-0 defeat at the hands of formidable Japan in their opening match of the AFC U20 Women's Asian Cup at the Thammasat Stadium here on Thursday.

Six-time champions Japan got the lead early on through an own goal by Thoibisana Chanu Toijam (12th minute).

However, it was not until the second half that Japan really managed to start hurting the Young Tigresses, with Miki Kimura (54th), Noa Fukushima (57th), Natsumi Tago (75th), Miyu Matsunaga (81st) and Yura Honda (87th) netting one each.

India, playing their first Asian Cup match in 20 years, had a good start early on, with Shubhangi Singh and Sulanjana Raul combining well on the left to set Sibani Devi Nongmeikapam through. The latter's low cutback, however, was intercepted.

Japan, however, were quick

Highlights

» Six-time champions Japan got the lead early on through an own goal by Thoibisana Chanu Toijam

» Japan, however, were quick to respond, and two minutes later, Kimura thudded the crossbar with her left-footed effort

to respond, and two minutes later, Kimura thudded the crossbar with her left-footed effort.

They got the early lead that they wanted, though luck may have been on their side for the opening goal. Fukushima's accurate free-kick from the right flank found the head of Japan defender Mitsuki Ota inside the Indian box. While it was somewhat of a glancing header, it struck India centre-back Thoibisana's feet before totally changing direction and going in.

While the gulf in quality was there to see, India did not lose hope and kept probing for a way back into the match.

Monalisha made a smart 21st-minute save off Anon Tsuda, before Sulanjana made a fine run down the left at the other end.

The latter drilled in a low cross, but it was inches from Lhingdeikim's feet.

The Young Tigresses began to grow into the game as the half-hour mark approached, and a 24th-minute free-kick by Anju Chanu Kayenpaibam found the head of Thoibisana inside the Japan box, but the centre-back was flagged offside.

While India gave a good account of themselves in the first half, Japan tightened their grip on the game after the change of ends.

AGENCIES

KITG: Chhattisgarh bag women's football gold

RAIPUR: Aided by the individual brilliance of their captain Kiran Pinda, Chhattisgarh women's football team continued their solid run in the inaugural Khelo India Tribal Games, defeating Jharkhand 1-0 in the final on their way to securing a gold medal.

The hosts also added the men's 4x400m relay silver and men's 1500m bronze to their overall tally on the penultimate day of track & field competitions in Jagdalpur.

Further, Jharkhand's Shiv Kumar Soren completed a grand double by adding the 200m gold to his 100m triumph.

The Chhattisgarh women's team made the most of the solitary chance they got against the aggressive

Jharkhand outfit when their captain pounced on a defensive lapse to score in the 61st minute and then the host team held on to the advantage to clinch the title.

"It's a special moment for us because this is the first time so many fans came to support us and I am very happy that we could win the gold medal in front of our home crowd," said an elated Kiran, the only international player in the home squad.

In Jagdalpur, the last day of athletics competitions saw Soren and Karnataka's Reethushree and Nagini claiming their second gold medal on the track at Kreedra Parisar complex.

Soren clinched the 200m gold with a time of 21.51s.

AGENCIES

This is just the beginning of Mohammed Shami's road to redemption: Pujara

The out-of-favour India pacer was acquired by LSG for Rs 10 crore in a trade

NEW DELHI: This is just the beginning of Mohammed Shami's road to redemption, said former India batter Cheteshwar Pujara on Thursday, referring to the veteran seamer's miserly spell for Lucknow Super Giants in their IPL match against Delhi Capitals.

The out-of-favour India pacer was acquired by LSG for Rs 10 crore in a trade with Sunrisers Hyderabad during the pre-auction window. Shami marked his LSG debut by becoming the first bowler in IPL history to claim five first-ball wickets.

Speaking about Shami's effort against DC, Pujara told broadcaster Star Sports, "This season of the IPL is very important for Mohammed Shami and



Mohammed Shami

the way he started off the tournament with this performance against DC shows he means business. "Yes, his figures read 1 for 28, but it was Shami who played a crucial role in helping

his side get off to a strong start in the powerplay. He first got rid of KL Rahul on the very first ball of the run chase and full credit to Shami."

Despite the six-wicket loss

to Delhi Capitals, Shami's opening spell highlighted his form following a 67-wicket domestic season.

"He knew that Rahul loves to play the inside out shot, so he bowled a wide delivery. Rahul played the inside out shot but it went straight into the hands of the deep point fielder. Then, he restricted the run flow by bowling tight lines and did not allow the batters to score runs."

"Shami has been playing domestic cricket across all formats in the last one year and the performances have been good. He is translating his domestic form into the IPL. This performance against Delhi is just the beginning of Mohammed Shami's road to redemption," Pujara said.

AGENCIES

It's the match-winning performance I was waiting for a long time: Nitish

KOLKATA: Nitish Kumar Reddy, who played a key role in Sunrisers Hyderabad's 65-run win over Kolkata Knight Riders, said he had been waiting for such a performance for a long time after his all-round show helped his side register their first win of the IPL season here on Thursday.

Heinrich Klaasen (52) and Reddy (39) provided the late charge as SRH posted a challenging 226 for 8. Reddy (2/17) also chipped in with the ball as KKR were bowled out for 161 in 16 overs.

"It's the match-winning performance I was waiting for a long time. Thankfully it came at the right time, and even my bowling, it's given me confidence. Just trying to be positive," Nitish said at the post match presentation.

'There have been too many negative thoughts in my mind because the last season didn't go my way and I couldn't bowl last season'

"There have been too many negative thoughts in my mind because the last season didn't go my way and I couldn't bowl last season."

"I've worked really hard on my bowling and it's paying off, and that really makes you feel happy and I am happy now. Thanks to the trainers and physios, my body is fully fit now."

AGENCIES

APPENDIX IV-A

Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(b) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the following described Immovable Property mortgaged to India SMC Asset Reconstruction Company Limited [CIN : U67190MH2008PLC181062] ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 20.04.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 26,61,544/- (Rupees Twenty Six Lakh Sixty One Thousand Five Hundred Forty Four only) pending towards Loan Account No. HHLSVA00421841, formerly known as (Hilabulls Housing Finance) and (Hilabulls Finance) and in favour of the Secured Creditor acting as a Trustee of ISARC - 2025 - 2026 + 2 Trust vide Assignment Agreement dated 26.12.2025. The Secured Creditor has duly taken over the financial facility from SCL and is, thus, vested with all powers and entitled to recover its outstanding dues in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) and / or enforcement of security interest in relation to the Immovable Property.

The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be Rs. 13,53,000/- (Rupees Thirteen Lakhs Fifty Three Thousand Only) and the Liquidated Damages Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 1,35,300/- (Rupees One Lakh Thirty Five Thousand Three Hundred Only), i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL OF FLAT NO. 301, HAVING COVERED AREA OF 51.09 SQ. MTRS., FIRST FLOOR, FRONT HAND RIGHT SIDE WITHOUT DOOR OF RIGHT), BUILT ON PLOT NO. A-712, DLF ANKUR VIHAR, RESIDENTIAL COLONY, LONI, GHAZIABAD - 201010, UTAR PRADESH. THE SAME IS BOUNDED AS UNDER:

EAST : FLAT NO. 302
WEST : PLOT NO. A-711
NORTH : 9 METER WIDER ROAD AT GROUND FLOOR
SOUTH : C. PASSAGE AND FLAT NO. 304

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in the Website of the Secured Creditor : e. www.isarc.in; Helpline No : 0124-6910610, - 91 7065451024; E-mail id: auctionhelpline@sammancapital.com For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in

sd/-
AUTHORISED OFFICIAL
INDIA SMC RECONSTRUCTION
COMPANY LIMITED
Trustee of ISARC - 2025 - 2026 + 2 Trust

Date : 01.04.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.



'DON'T GLORIFY YOUR MOTHER'S PAIN'

'Subedaar' star Mona Singh talked about why 'Maa Ka Sum' feels different

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Mona Singh is quite literally on a roll of late. After surprising everyone with her fierce, never-before-seen avatar as mafia queen Babli Didi in Prime Video's 'Subedaar', she is turning the tables in a completely different role with 'Maa Ka Sum'. This time, Mona plays Vinitha, a modern single mother navigating love, life and self-discovery on her own terms. At the heart of this coming-of-age drama series is a dynamic you don't see often. A 19-year-old math whiz trying to 'solve' his mother's love life using mathematics, algorithms and logic, while she's simply trying to feel something real again. The actress talked about why her character is different from stereotypical mom roles and



what drew her to this role.

"I've played mothers before, but Vinitha felt very different to me. She's not written as this perfect, sacrificing figure we've seen for years. For the longest time, we've put mothers on a pedestal, where their entire identity is about giving and giving. But Vinitha breaks away from that. She's a mother, yes, but she's also a woman with her own life, her own choices and her own desires. She wants companionship; she's open to dating and she's figuring things out on her own terms. That honesty is what really drew me to the character; it felt real and very today," Mona said.

She added, "I feel it's important, especially for younger audiences, to see their mothers as individuals first."

'Vinitha felt very different to me. She's not written as this perfect, sacrificing figure we've seen for years,' she says

THREADED HERITAGE

Symbolism, Ritual & Memory in Northeast Textiles

The India International Centre (IIC) presents 'Threaded Heritage: Symbolism, Ritual and Memory in Northeast Textiles', a new exhibition that explores how textiles act as a visual language expressing cultural iconography and meaning.

Curated by Sentila T Yanger, the exhibition will be accompanied by live demonstrations by weavers from the Northeast at the gallery.

Patterns, motifs and colours often communicate cultural narratives representing cosmologies, social status, kinship and connections to land and ancestry. Within these designs, threads become symbols that articulate identity and belonging.

Equally significant is the ritualistic role of textiles within cul-

tural practices. From ceremonial garments to sacred cloths used in rites of passage, textiles often mediate moments of transformation - birth, marriage, initiation and death. In these contexts, fabric moves beyond functionality to become an object of spiritual and communal significance.

By presenting textiles as living archives of memory, 'Threaded Heritage' is a textile exhibition that explores the rich cultural identity, history and artistry woven into the tradi-

tional textiles of Northeast India. It invites audiences to reflect on the enduring power of thread as a metaphor and material of connection.

To be on view at the Art Gallery, Kamaladevi Complex, IIC, the exhibition will run till April 12, 7 pm.



'Dhurandhar' in every way is a revelation: Priyanka

Chopra called Aditya Dhar 'a man with a mission'

Priyanka Chopra Jonas heaped praise on 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', calling director Aditya Dhar 'a man with a mission' and the film 'a revelation in every way'.

The actress shared the film's poster on 'Instagram Stories' and also gave a shout-out to Ranveer Singh, her co-star from films 'Dil Dhadakne Do', 'Gunday' and 'Bajirao Mastani'.

"Congratulations, mere dost @ranveersingh," said the actor, who is currently in India. She also tagged other cast members - Arjun Rampal, R Madhavan, Akshaye Khanna, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun and Rakesh Bedi.

"Aditya, you're a man with a mission. 'Dhurandhar' in every way is a revelation. Thank you all for your artistry," she wrote.

A sequel to Dhar's 2025 blockbuster 'Dhurandhar', the film released on March 19 in Hindi, Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam. It stars Singh alongside R Madhavan, Arjun Rampal, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun and Rakesh Bedi.

Set in Lyari town of Karachi, an



area known for its history of gang wars and violent turf battles, 'Dhurandhar' revolved around covert intelligence operations against the backdrop of geopolitical and terror events like the Kandahar plane hijack, the 2001 Parliament Attack and the 26/11 Mumbai attacks.

The sequel charts the rise of Ranveer Singh's character Hamza Ali Mazari in the Karachi underworld.

57TH SHANKAR SHAD MUSHAIRA

CELEBRATE THE SOUL OF URDU SHAYARI

The event pulls in voices from every corner of the map, representing the true heart of the country

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The Shankar Lal Murli Dhar Memorial Society is set to breathe life back into Delhi's longest-running public 'mushaira' on April 4, 2026, at 7 pm. Taking place at Modern School, Barakhamba, the '57th Shankar Shad Mushaira' continues a tradition that has anchored the city's cultural calendar since 1954. This stage has long been a true home for the Urdu language, where the legends of the past and the boldest voices of today meet to protect a depth of storytelling that remains rare.

Organised by the Shankar Lal Murli Dhar Memorial Society in association with DCM Shriram Industries Ltd, this year's 'mushaira' marks a significant shift as the event brings a pan-India flavour to the capital. While digital reels might vanish in 24 hours, the verses shared on this stage are etched into memory through voice and tradition. This platform stands alone in its honouring of the legacy of the original 'mushaira', continuing the etiquette and grace that defined the gatherings of the past. It serves as a bridge where the classical meets the contemporary, ensuring that the soul of Urdu poetry evolves without being diluted.

The 57th edition pulls in voices from every corner of the map, representing the true heart of the country. From the rugged landscapes of the North to the vibrant pulse of our cities, poets are converging in Delhi to find the common language that connects us all. The lineup is a rare meeting of eras, headlined by the timeless Waseem Barelvi and the legendary Javed Akhtar. These masters share the stage with a new guard of storytellers, including veterans such as Sheen Kaaf Nizam, Iqbal Ashhar, Rajesh Reddy, Shakeel Azmi and Shabeena Adee. They are joined by the raw, contemporary energy of Charan Singh Bashir, Azhar Iqbal, Sunil Kumar Tang, Hina Haider Rizvi, Saif Nizami and Zubair Ali Tabish. Each 'shayar' and 'shayaras' brings the unique flavour of their home state, proving that while our dialects might be different, our heartbeats and our loves are the same.

As the 2026 edition draws near, the Society is widening its embrace through the '2nd Shankar Shad Shayari Contest', inviting every hidden voice to step out from the shadows of their private journals and onto this historic platform. By welcoming both written and video submissions, the search for new talent ensures that the 'next great heart' of Indian poetry has a home regardless of age or background.

The official announcement of the contest winners will take place on April 4, 2026, at the 'Shankar Shad Mushaira', celebrating emerging talent in the presence of legendary artists.



It serves as a bridge where the classical meets the contemporary, ensuring that the soul of Urdu poetry evolves without being diluted

For the younger generation, this space has become vital. Gen Z is returning to 'Shankar Shad Mushaira' to find a language for things that are often hard to talk about - mental health, the weight of identity and the ache of heartbreak. It has become a haven for emotional expression and healing. This year, the event also honours the diversity of India through its inclusivity. We see women 'shayars' reclaiming their voices and a linguistic blend that welcomes Hindi and Hindustani dialects alongside Urdu. It is a night where silence often speaks louder than applause, where the emotional pauses between lines carry as much weight as the words themselves.

Reflecting on this journey, Madhav Bansidhar Shriram, Chairman of the Shankar Lal Murli Dhar Society and Managing Director of DCM Shriram Industries Ltd, shared that the 'Shankar Shad Mushaira' is a sanctuary where the 'restless spirit finally finds its reflection'. He mentioned how we live in a world that has totally forgotten the value of a pause. Here, we provide a space where words carry the weight of existence and silence is sacred. As he noted: "By gathering a pan-India brotherhood of poets, we unite the different threads of our national heritage. This stage belongs to every Indian who has ever found comfort in a story. We are protecting the very breath of our culture. This is a soul that belongs to everyone."



THE LOOM & THE LENS: WEAVING STORIES. FRAMING LEGACY

BRINGING HANDLOOM & CINEMA TOGETHER AT IFFD 2026

The showcase brought together the timeless narratives of Indian handloom and cinema in a visually compelling and culturally resonant presentation

OUR CORRESPONDENT

On the sidelines of the International Film Festival Delhi (IFFD), a grand and evocative fashion showcase titled 'The Loom & The Lens: Weaving Stories. Framing Legacy' was organised by Delhi Tourism, Government of Delhi and the Development Commissioner (Handlooms), Government of India, in collaboration with 'Shikha's Kariigari'. Held at the Open Air Amphitheatre, Bharat Mandapam, the showcase brought together the timeless narratives of Indian handloom and cinema in a visually compelling and culturally resonant presentation.

Speaking on the occasion, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "IFFD Delhi is a celebration of cinema, India's cultural imagination and storytelling legacy. Initiatives like 'The Loom & The Lens' beautifully position Delhi as a confluence of heritage and modern creativity, where traditional art forms such as handloom find renewed expression through contemporary plat-

forms like cinema. This is how we present India's cultural depth to the world, which is vibrant, rooted and forward-looking."

Gupta further added, "Handloom and cinema are two of India's most powerful storytelling traditions - one woven through threads, the other through frames of light. Together, they preserve our collective memory and identity. The saree has remained an enduring symbol across generations, gracefully capturing the spirit of India in both everyday life and cinematic expression."

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra said, "The International Film Festival Delhi is emerging as a global cultural platform and through initiatives like 'The Loom & The Lens', we are expanding its canvas beyond cinema. This showcase reflects the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshth Bharat' by bringing together diverse handloom traditions from across India and presenting them through the powerful medium of fashion and film."

He further added, "Delhi Tourism is committed to promoting such



innovative cultural integrations, where handlooms, cinema and creative industries converge. This not only strengthens our cultural narrative globally but also creates meaningful visibility and opportunities for our weavers and artisans."

Adding to this, Suneel Anchipaka, MD & CEO, Delhi Tourism & Transportation Development Corporation (DT&TDC), said, "'The Loom & The Lens' stands out as a visually captivating and

conceptually rich presentation at IFFD 2026. The way it seamlessly wove together cinematic nostalgia, regional handloom diversity and artistic expression into thematic sequences is truly commendable. Platforms like IFFD enable us to showcase Delhi not just as a host city, but as a vibrant cultural curator connecting tradition with contemporary storytelling."

The fashion presentation featured three thematic sequences.

The opening sequence, 'Handloom to Silver Screen', revisited iconic saree drapes inspired by memorable cinematic moments from the 1940s to the 2020s, highlighting how Indian films have played a pivotal role in popularising the saree as a symbol of elegance and cultural identity.

'Handloom to Silver Screen' revisited iconic saree drapes inspired by memorable cinematic moments from the 1940s to the 2020s

The second sequence, 'From the Weavers of India', showcased the rich diversity of Indian handlooms - from 'Tussar' and 'Gheecha' of Chhattisgarh to 'Banarasi Butidar' of Varanasi, 'Lachcha Buta' of

Mubarakpur, 'Chanderi' of Madhya Pradesh, 'Venkatagiri' of Andhra Pradesh and 'Kuthampully' of Kerala - each representing the living traditions and craftsmanship of India's weaving communities.

The grand finale, 'Ek Bharat, Shreshth Bharat: A Tribute to Vande Mataram', presented Shikha's signature collection of hand-painted handloom sarees inspired by traditional Indian art forms, including Pichwai, Pattachitra, Warli, Gond, Madhubani, Assamese traditions and 'Chittara' art. Marking the 150th anniversary of the iconic song 'Vande Mataram', the finale transformed the ramp into a moving canvas of national pride, unity and artistic expression, set to its stirring notes.

Appreciating IFFD and the support from the Delhi Government, Dr M Beena, Development Commissioner (Handlooms), said, "It is heartening to see handloom being integrated into a global cultural platform like IFFD. Such initiatives help present handloom in innovative formats, linking it with cinema and storytelling, while reinforcing its

relevance in today's cultural and creative economy."

Expressing her gratitude, Shikha Ajmera, artist, fashion designer and promoter of 'Shikha's Kariigari', said, "For me, a saree isn't just a garment, but a moving canvas. Through this showcase, we have attempted to bring together the narratives of loom and lens, where tradition meets storytelling, and art becomes a lived experience."

'Shikha's Kariigari' continues to work closely with nationally recognised artisans, transforming traditional art forms into wearable expressions while ensuring sustainable livelihoods and preservation of heritage crafts.

Directed by fashion director Sandesh Navlakha, with expert choreography and styling, the showcase culminated in a visually immersive and emotionally stirring experience, earning widespread appreciation from audiences and dignitaries alike. The evening stood out as a defining moment at IFFD Delhi 2026, where fashion transcended aesthetics to become a powerful medium of storytelling, culture and national pride.